# HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

## FACULTY OF PRACTICAL THEOLOGY

## DEPARTMENT OF ETHICS AND ORTHODOX SPRITUALITY

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| **Course Title** | **Introduction to Holy Scriptures** |
| **Course Code** | 201 |
| **Credit Hours** | 3 |
| **COURSE INSTRUCTOR** | Mhr. FASIL ASMAMAW(Doctor Of Education Candidate Strategy Leadership And Educational Policy, Masters Of Practical Theology And Masters Of Inclusive Education) fasiltheo24@gmail.com (0913712028) |
| **Faculty**<br>**Department**<br>**Semester and Academic Year:** | **Holy Trinity Theological University**<br>**Faculty Of Practical Theology**<br>**Department Of Ethics And Orthodox Spirituality, Year 1, Semester II**<br>2016/ 2024 |
| **Course Description** | Welcome to the course *"Introduction to Holy Scripture"* which aims to provide you with a comprehensive understanding of the Orthodox approach to the Scripture, its interpretation, and its use in worship and prayer. Throughout the course, we will explore the history, canon, interpretation, and use of scripture within the Orthodox Church.<br>We will engage with primary Orthodox sources, including the writings of the Church Fathers and liturgical texts. The course will also examine the Orthodox approach to interpreting scripture. By the end of the course, you will have gained a thorough understanding of the Orthodox approach to the Scripture and its significance in the life of the Orthodox Church. Our goal is to deepen your understanding of the Scripture and the Orthodox Christian faith. |

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| | We are excited to embark on this journey of exploration and discovery with you. |
| **Course Objective** | The course note and the reading documents will be provided in advance. Students are strongly encouraged to read the documents thoroughly, and expected to come to the class with a summary of the specific text own critical views and reflective comments are contained.<br>**Learning outcomes or Objectives:** Engaged Learning<br>In this course, you will have the opportunity to become an engaged learner, one who<br>• Sets personal goals to participate, and evaluates progress;<br>• Prepares for class in order to teach others and to ask informed questions;<br>• Engages in respectful and collaborative discussion, taking responsibility for classroom dynamics;<br>• Expands the ability to learn in different ways, and to transfer knowledge bases;<br>• Researches a topic of interest, taking initiative to extend beyond required assignments<br>**Learning Activities**<br>1. Carefully read the preliminary section in this independent study textbook.<br>2. Read this lesson′s introductory section, outline, and Objective.<br>3. Look over the key words. If they are not familiar to check their meanings in different dictionaries.<br>4. Study the lesson development. Look up and read all references.<br>**5.** Take the self-test at the end of the lesson |

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| **Course Content/Outline** | **Chapter 1: The Holy Scripture: An Introduction**<br><br>The objective of Lesson one is to provide an introduction to Holy Scripture, including its definition, etymology, and the meanings of key terms for Scriptural studies. Additionally, this course aims to explore the definition of ''Testament'' and ''Covenant'' and the unity of the two covenants and the challenges to their unity.<br><br>• Explain the etymological definition of '*Scripture'* and '*Bible'*, and the significance of the term.<br>• Define term *'Testament'* and *'Covenant'* and understand its significance in relation to scripture<br>• Understand the unity and difference of the Old and New Covenants and the challenges in understanding their unity.<br>• Understand the importance of studying Scripture.<br>**Chapter 2: The holy Scriptures of World Religions**<br>The objective of Lesson two is to introduce students to the concept of Religious Scriptures, their importance and roles in different faiths, and to classify them based on their characteristics.<br><br>Define what is meant by Religious Scriptures.<br><br>• Understand the importance of Religious Scriptures in various Religions.<br>• Identify different characteristics that can be used to classify Religious Scriptures, such as their origin, content, and authority.<br>• Develop a basic understanding of the variety of religious scriptures found in different religions.<br><br>**Chapter 3: Divine Inspiration and Revelation**<br><br>The objective of Lesson three is to explore the concept of Divine Inspiration and Revelation within the context of the Orthodox Christian Tradition.<br><br>• Define the terms of the *Divine Inspiration* and *Revelation,* and explain their importance in Orthodox Theology and Spirituality.<br><br>• Distinguish between different types of revelation (e.g. verbal, written, direct, indirect, etc.) and explain their significance in Orthodox |

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| | theology.<br><br>• Reflect on their own experiences of prayer and discernment and consider how they relate to the Orthodox concept of Divine Inspiration and Revelation.<br><br>**Chapter 4: The Holy Scripture in Orthodox Christianity (Church, Tradition and Scriptures).**<br><br>The Objective of this lesson is to provides an introduction to the role of Holy Scripture in the Orthodox Church, including its relationship with Church and Tradition. Topics covered include the Orthodox view of Holy Scripture, the relationship between Church and Scripture, and the relationship between Tradition and Scripture.<br>• Understand the Orthodox view of Holy Scripture.<br>• Understand the relationship between Church, Tradition and Scripture in the Orthodox tradition.<br>• Understand **Scripture is not the sole rule of faith in the Holy Church.**<br>**Chapter 5: The Canonization of Holy Scripture in Orthodox Church**<br>This Lesson is an introduction to the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church. The lessons explore the historical development of the canon, the role of the canon in Orthodox Theology and practice, and the differences between the Orthodox, Catholic, and Protestant canons of Scripture.<br><br>• Provide an overview of the development of the Scriptural canon in the Orthodox Church, including the criteria used to determine which books were accepted and which were rejected.<br>• Examine the role of Tradition in the formation of the Scriptural canon, including the importance of the writings of the Church Fathers and Early Christians.<br>• Explore the theological and practical implications of the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church.<br>• Compare and contrast the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church |

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| | with other Christian traditions, such as the Catholic and Protestant canons.<br>**Chapter 6: The Language and Versions of the Holy Scripture**<br>This Lesson provides an overview of the various languages and versions of the Scripture, including their history, development, and translations. The Lesson explores about the major languages in which the Bible was originally written, such as Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek, as well as the different versions that have been produced throughout history. They will also explore the challenges and opportunities involved in translating the Scripture from one language to another.<br><br>Understand the history and development of the major languages in which the Scripture was written.<br>• Understand the various versions of the Scripture that have been produced throughout history.<br>• Appreciate the challenges and opportunities involved in translating the Scripture from one language to another.<br>• Equip with the skills necessary to critically evaluate different translations of the Scripture.<br>**Chapter 7: Interpretation of Holy Scripture in Orthodox Tradition**<br>This Lesson provides an introduction to the interpretation of Holy Scripture in the Orthodox Church tradition. The lesson explores about the theological, historical, and cultural contexts in which Orthodox Scriptural interpretation developed. The lesson also explores the various methods and approaches to Scriptural interpretation used by Orthodox Theologians throughout history.<br>• Understand of the theological, historical, and cultural contexts in which Orthodox biblical interpretation developed.<br>• Familiar with various methods and approaches to biblical interpretation used by Orthodox theologians and scholars throughout history.<br>• Gain the skills necessary to engage in faithful interpretation of Holy Scripture in the Orthodox tradition.<br>**Chapter 8: Ethiopian holy Scriptural Interpretation**<br>This lesson provides an introduction to the rich tradition of biblical |

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| | interpretation in *Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahido Church*. The lesson explores the theological, historical, and cultural contexts in which Ethiopian Scriptural interpretation developed, as well as the various methods and approaches to Scriptural interpretation used by Ethiopian theologians and scholars throughout history.<br>Through a close reading of selected Scriptural texts and commentaries, the course aims to deepen students' understanding of the distinctive features of Ethiopian Scriptural interpretation and its significance for contemporary theological discussions.<br><br>• Analyze and explain the distinctive features of Ethiopian Scriptural interpretation, including its theological, historical, and cultural contexts.<br>• Evaluate the different methods and approaches to Scriptural interpretation used by Ethiopian theologians and scholars throughout history.<br>• Synthesize and compare Ethiopian Orthodox Scriptural interpretation with others.<br>• Demonstrate an understanding of the relevance and significance of Ethiopian Scriptural interpretation for contemporary theological discussions.<br>**Chapter 9: Reading the Scriptures from an Orthodox Perspective**<br>This lesson provides an introduction to reading the Scriptures from an Orthodox Christian perspective. Through a close reading of selected Scriptural texts and commentaries, the course aims to deepen students' understanding of the distinctive features of Orthodox Scriptural reading.<br><br>• Understand the basic principles and practices of reading Holy Scriptures.<br>• Reflect on one's own spiritual and ethical development through the process of reading and interpreting Holy Scriptures.<br>• Develop personal strategies for reading and engaging with Holy Scriptures in Orthodox Tradition. |

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| | **Chapter 10: Scripture in Orthodox Church: Liturgical and Pedagogical Aspects**<br>This lesson explores the role of Scripture in the life of the Orthodox Church, with a focus on its liturgical and pedagogical aspects. The lesson examines the contexts in which Orthodox liturgical and pedagogical practices developed, as well as the ways in which Scripture is used in Orthodox worship and education. The lesson aims to deepen students' understanding of the importance of Scripture in Orthodox Christian life and practice.<br><br>• Analyze and evaluate the liturgical and pedagogical uses of Scripture in Orthodox worship and education.<br>• Appreciate the significance and relevance of Orthodox liturgical and pedagogical practices for contemporary theological discussions.<br><br>**Chapter 11: Survey on Old Testament**<br><br>This lesson explores the Old Testament in the Orthodox Christian Tradition. The lesson examines the Orthodox Christian approach to interpreting and applying the Old Testament, as well as its relevance for contemporary Orthodox Christian life and practice. The course aims to deepen students' understanding of the Old Testament and its significance for Orthodox Christian faith and spirituality.<br><br>• Understand the theological and historical contexts of the Old Testament in the Orthodox Christian Tradition.<br>• Analyze and evaluate the Orthodox Christian approach to interpreting and applying the Old Testament.<br>• Appreciate the significance and relevance of the Old Testament for contemporary Christian life and practice.<br><br>**Chapter 12: Survey on New Testament**<br><br>This lesson explores the New Testament in the Orthodox Christian tradition. |

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| | The lesson examines the Orthodox Christian approach to interpreting and applying the New Testament, as well as its relevance for contemporary Christian life and practice. The course aims to deepen students' understanding of the New Testament and its significance for Orthodox Christian faith and spirituality.<br><br>• Read the entirety of the New Testament and become familiar with its authors, genres and contents<br>• Understand the various methodologies currently employed in New Testament studies, and develop an appreciation for the perspective on the biblical text each affords<br>• To provide students with a basic understanding of the history and content of the New Testament.<br><br>**Chapter 13: Holy Scripture Geography and Culture**<br>The lesson on Scriptural Geography and Culture is an interdisciplinary study of the physical, social, cultural, and historical aspects of the Scriptural world. The lesson explores the geography and culture of both the Old and New Testaments and examines how these elements intersect with the stories and teachings of the Scripture. The lesson will also explore the role of archaeology in biblical studies, including the methods of archaeological research and the ways in which archaeological discoveries can shed light on scriptural narratives and teachings.<br><br>• Develop a comprehensive understanding of the physical, social, cultural, and historical context of the Scriptural world, including the geography and culture of both the Old and New Testaments.<br>• Examine the ways in which geography and culture influenced the stories and teachings of the Scripture, and how Scriptural texts can shed light on the geography and culture of the Scriptural world.<br>• Explore the role of archaeology in Scriptural studies and how archaeological discoveries can provide insights into the social, cultural, and religious life of the Scriptural world. |

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| | **Chapter 14: The Holy Scripture Today: Modern Biblical Scholarships**<br>This lesson will explore modern biblical scholarships and criticism, and their problem. The lesson will examine the different methods of interpretation used by scholars today.<br><br>• Understand the various methods of modern biblical criticism, including historical-critical, literary, and cultural approaches.<br>• Discuss the impact of modern biblical criticism on contemporary society and religious communities.<br>• Understand the the Church position on modern biblical scholarship.<br><br>**Chapter 15: Holy Scripture for contemporary world**<br><br>This lesson explores the Holy Scripture as a relevant text for the contemporary world. The lesson examines how the Scriptures speaks to contemporary issues and challenges facing individuals and communities today.<br><br>• Understand the relevance of the Holy Scriptures to contemporary society and current issues.<br>• Examine how the Holy Scriptures speaks to contemporary issues, such as social justice, environmental stewardship etc. |
| **Reading List** | **Chapter *1.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Ewert, David. *A general introduction to the Bible: From ancient tablets to modern translations*. Zondervan, 2010. Chapter 1.<br>• Pentiuc, Eugen J. *The Old Testament in Eastern Orthodox Tradition*. Oxford University Press, 2014. Part I, Chapter 1.<br>**Chapter** 2. ***Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Van Voorst, Robert E. *Anthology of world scriptures*. Cengage Learning, 2016. Pp.1-20.<br>Hardy, Grant. *Sacred texts of the world*. Teaching Company, 2014. Pp. 4-10. |

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| | **Chapter *3.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Ewert, David. *A general introduction to the Bible: From ancient tablets to modern translations*. Zondervan, 2010.<br>• Dockery, David S. *Christian scripture: An evangelical perspective on inspiration, authority and interpretation*. Wipf and Stock Publishers, 2004.<br>**Chapter *4.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Florovsky, Georges. *Bible, church, tradition: an Eastern Orthodox view*. Vol. 1. Lulu. com, 1972.<br>**Chapter *5.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Pentiuc, Eugen J., Ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part II<br><br>**Chapter** 6.***Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Packer, J. I., John Piper, R. Kent Hughes, Leland Ryken, Vern S. Poythress, John D. Currid, Peter J. Gentry et al. *"Understanding Scripture: An Overview of the Bible's Origin, Reliability, and Meaning."* (2012).<br>**Chapter *7.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part IV.<br>**Chapter *8.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part IV. Chapter 25.<br>**Chapter *9.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part IV. Chapter 25.<br>**Chapter *10.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part II (Chapter 12), Part IV (Chapter 28).<br>**Chapter *11.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Pentiuc, Eugen J. *The Old Testament in Eastern Orthodox Tradition*. Oxford |

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| | University Press, 2014.<br>**Chapter *12.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Theodore G. Stylianopoulos, The New Testament: An Orthodox Perspective, vol. 1: Scripture, Tradition, Hermeneutics (Brookline, MA: Holy Cross Orthodox Press, 1997).<br>**Chapter *13.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>Baly, D. The Geography of the Bible: A Study in Historical Geography(1957): 303pp<br>**Chapter** 14.***Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Irish, Wm Norman. "Modern Biblical Criticism." *The Old Testament Student* 3, no. 2 (1883): 39-49.<br>•<br>**Chapter *15.Recommend Reading Materials***<br>• Bauckham, Richard. *The Bible in the Contemporary World: Hermeneutical Ventures*. Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing, 2015. |
| **Grading System Result :** | 96-100 = A+;<br>90-95 = A;<br>85-89 = A-;<br>80-84 = B+;<br>75-79 = B;<br>70-74= B-;<br>60-69 = C;<br>50-59 = D;<br>49 – F |
| **I. Methods of delivery**<br>**II. Class rule**: | ✓ Teacher presentation-kick-off assessment approaches<br>✓ Independent learning - readings, reporting, reflections etc<br>✓ Preparation of seminar papers and presentation<br>✓ Critique and systematic reviews on research article, |

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| | ✓ Seminar papers<br>✓ Empirical Study - Analysis Project<br>✓ Participation in paper presentation and making sound comments<br><br>Please respect the following rules, which are intended to ensure that everyone in this class has an interesting and enjoyable learning experience:<br><br>✓ Attendance: Students are expected to attend all class sessions unless documentation is given excusing an absence for medical, religious or personal reasons, or for official university works. Students must notify the instructor as soon as possible (preferably in advance) of the reason for the absence. Please come to class on time.<br>✓ Expected Time Allocated per Week: In addition to the 3 hrs of class room contact hrs. Per week, students should anticipate investing 4-5 additional hours reading and preparing for this class during an average week. The amount of assigned readings varies from week to week. When you have a lighter workload, I also encourage you to be pro-active in your preparation for coming weeks.<br>✓ In order to foster an environment of constructive participation, I strongly recommend you read the assignments in advance of class and be ready to engage in the subject. Advanced preparation will help you benefit from the lectures more readily and actively engage in class discussions. You should also use these discussion forums as opportunities to enhance your communication skills: you should aim to build logical arguments, with sound evidence, and explicit consideration of alternative perspectives.<br>✓ I may adjust the readings as necessary – you are responsible for any changes to the readings.<br>✓ Cell Phones and related devices: Before you enter the classroom, turn off all cell phones, pagers, blackberries, and other electronic devises.<br>✓ If you have lengthy questions or comments about the course, I encourage you to come and talk to me in person. In addition to |

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| | regular office hours, I am happy to set up appointments to meet with you. Please keep email communications brief.<br>✓ There are only two exceptions to the late-assignment policy: illness or family emergency. If either of these circumstances applies, you must provide written documentation (such as a doctor's note if you are ill), and you must communicate with me before the assignment is due (i.e., emailing me on the morning the assignment is due and saying you are sick is not acceptable for avoiding a penalty).<br>✓ |
| **Type of Exam and Evaluation** | Result will be given based on student's class participation and interactive discussion on the reading documents, and of course the final exam.<br><br>Students will be provided list of questions related to each topic discussed in the class to study and prepare them for the exam.<br><br>On the exam day, the student will choose four or five questions out of the list and give the answer in a separate paper.<br><br>Unannounced and unscheduled quizzes<br>Book Review<br>Class presentation and individual review<br>Final Examination<br><br>ATTENDANCE ……..10<br><br>INDIVIDUAL ASSSIGNMENT ……20%<br><br>GROUP ASSIGNMENT AND FILED WORK……..…...20%<br><br>MID EXAM ……..……..20%<br><br>FINAL EXAM …….....30% |

# CHAPTER ONE

## The Scriptures of World Religions

The objective of Lesson one is to introduce students to the concept of Religious Scriptures, their importance and roles in different faiths, and to classify them based on their characteristics.

**At the end of this lesson, Students will be able to:**

- Define what is meant by Religious Scriptures.
- Understand the importance of Religious Scriptures in various Religions.
- Identify different characteristics that can be used to classify Religious Scriptures, such as their origin, content, and authority.
- Develop a basic understanding of the variety of religious scriptures found in different religions.

The term "sacred" comes from the Latin word "*sacer*", which means "holy" or "consecrated". The word "text" comes from the Latin "textus", meaning "a thing woven". The combination of these two words suggests that a "sacred text" is a woven or interwoven collection of words or writings that are regarded as holy or consecrated by a particular religious or spiritual community. Also, a "sacred text or scripture" can be defined as a religious or spiritual document or artifact. The term "sacred text" is often used to describe religious or spiritual documents that are believed to have been revealed or inspired by a deity or other supernatural force. These texts are often considered by the religious groups to be the ultimate source of truth or wisdom, and their teachings may be regarded as infallible or immutable.

Sacred texts often contain teachings, formation that is believed to have been revealed or inspired by a deity or other supernatural force. These texts may also provide guidance or instructions on how to live a good and righteous life, and may be used in religious rituals or ceremonies. They are often highly valued and revered by believers, and are considered to be a central part of the religious or spiritual tradition to which they belong. Sacred texts can play a variety of roles in a religious or spiritual community. They may serve as the basis for religious law or doctrine, and provide a framework for ethical behavior and moral values.

They may also be used in prayer or other forms of worship, and provide a means of connecting with the divine or spiritual realm. In addition, sacred texts may serve as a source of historical or cultural knowledge, preserving the traditions and beliefs of a particular group over time.

Sacred scriptures play a central role in many religious and spiritual traditions, providing a framework for belief and practice, and guiding individuals and communities in their spiritual journeys. They may contain teachings, stories, or other information that is believed to offer insight into the nature of the divine or spiritual realm, and may provide guidance on how to live a good and righteous life. They may also be subject to ongoing interpretation and reinterpretation, as new generations of scholars and believers seek to understand their meaning and relevance in the present day. One of the defining features of a sacred text is its perceived authority or authenticity. Sacred texts are often considered to be the ultimate source of truth or wisdom, and their teachings may be considered to be infallible or immutable. However, this authority may be interpreted differently by different individuals or groups, leading to different interpretations or even conflicting beliefs.

Sacred texts may also be subject to ongoing interpretation and reinterpretation, as new generations of scholars and believers seek to understand their meaning and relevance in the present day. This can lead to debates and discussions over the correct interpretation of certain passages or teachings, and may result in the development of new religious movements or sects. Overall, sacred texts play a central role in many religious and spiritual traditions, serving as a source of guidance, inspiration, and connection to the divine or spiritual realm. They reflect the values, beliefs, and experiences of the communities that hold them sacred, and continue to shape the way that believers understand themselves and their place in the world. The concept of a sacred text has been present in many different cultures and traditions throughout history. In some cases, these texts were considered to be the literal word of God, while in other cases they were seen as a human interpretation of divine revelation. Regardless of their origin or nature, sacred texts are often treated with great reverence and respect, and are considered to be a central part of the religious or spiritual tradition to which they belong.

**The common role of scripture in world religions includes:**

0. **The educational role** of scripture in world religions is significant. Here are some ways in which scripture serves an educational function:

**Teachings and doctrines**: Scripture contains teachings and doctrines that provide guidance and instruction to believers. These teachings can be used to educate new converts, reinforce the faith of existing believers, and deepen understanding of religious principles.

**Morality and ethics**: Many scriptures contain moral and ethical teachings that are used to promote virtues such as compassion, forgiveness, and selflessness. These teachings can be used to educate believers on how to live a virtuous life and make ethical decisions.

**History and culture**: Scripture can serve as a means of preserving the history and culture of a particular religious tradition, as well as the values and beliefs of its adherents. This can be used to educate believers on the history of their faith, its development over time, and its cultural context.

**Language and literacy**: Scripture has been used historically as a means of promoting literacy and language acquisition. Many religious traditions encourage the study of their sacred texts as a means of developing language and literacy skills.

2. **Ritual and worship**: Scripture is often used in religious rituals and worship, such as readings during services, prayer, or meditation. This can help to reinforce the importance of the text and its teachings, as well as deepen the spiritual experience of believers.

Here are some ways in which scripture serves this function:

a) **Liturgy**: Scripture is often incorporated into liturgical practices, such as prayers, hymns, and readings. For example, in Christianity, scripture is often read aloud during church services, and in Islam, recitation of the Quran is an important part of daily prayer.

b) **Symbolism**: Many scriptures contain symbolic language that is incorporated into religious rituals and practices. For example, in Hinduism, the Vedas contain many symbolic rituals and practices that are still performed today, such as the ritual of fire sacrifice.

c) **Sacred space**: Many religious traditions believe that certain spaces are sacred, and scripture is often used to establish and maintain these spaces. For example, in Judaism, the Torah is kept in a special ark in the synagogue, which serves as a physical manifestation of the sacredness of the scripture.

d) **Sacrifice**: Some religious traditions incorporate scripture into practices of sacrifice or offering. For example, in Hinduism, the Bhagavad Gita contains teachings on the importance of sacrifice, and the tradition of puja involves offering food, flowers, and other objects to a deity in a ritualized manner.
e) **Commemoration**: Many religious rituals are performed in commemoration of important events or figures in the history of a particular religious tradition. Scripture is often used to help believers remember and honor these events and figures. For example, in Christianity, the Eucharist is performed in remembrance of Jesus' last supper with his disciples, and in Islam, the celebration of Eid al-Adha commemorates Abraham's willingness to sacrifice his son.

3. **Community building:** Many religious communities are built around shared beliefs and practices, including the study and interpretation of scripture. The shared experience of reading and discussing scripture can help to build a sense of community and common purpose among believers. The role of scripture in world religions also extends to community building. Sacred texts often serve as a unifying force for religious communities, providing a shared source of knowledge, beliefs, and practices. Scripture can be used to establish and reinforce social norms, values, and ethics that guide the behavior of individuals within the community.

In many religious traditions, scripture is used as a tool for fostering a sense of solidarity among believers. Reading and discussing scripture together can create a sense of shared experience and promote feelings of mutual respect and understanding. Additionally, many religious communities use scripture as a means of outreach, sharing their beliefs with others and inviting them to join in communal worship and study. Scripture can also play a role in building bridges between different religious communities. Interfaith dialogue and cooperation are increasingly important in a globalized world, and the shared reverence for scripture can provide a common ground for such efforts. By highlighting the similarities between different religious traditions and promoting understanding and tolerance, scripture can contribute to a more harmonious and peaceful world.

**4. Historical and cultural preservation:** Scripture can serve as a means of preserving the history and culture of a particular religious tradition, as well as the values and beliefs of its adherents. This can help to maintain a sense of continuity and connection to the past within a given community. Another role of scripture in world religions is to serve as a means of historical and cultural preservation. Many sacred texts contain historical narratives, genealogies, and other records that provide insights into the beliefs, practices, and cultures of the people who produced them.

For example, the Hebrew Bible contains a wealth of historical and cultural information about the ancient Israelites, including their religious beliefs, laws, and customs. Similarly, the Hindu Vedas and Upanishads offer insights into the religious practices and beliefs of ancient India.

In addition to preserving historical and cultural information, sacred texts can also play a role in shaping cultural identity. For many religious communities, scripture is a symbol of their unique cultural heritage and a source of pride in their traditions. By preserving and passing down their sacred texts, religious communities are able to maintain a sense of continuity with their past and ensure that their cultural identity is not lost over time. Finally, some religious traditions view their scriptures as divinely inspired or even as the very word of God. In these cases, the role of scripture extends beyond historical and cultural preservation to include spiritual significance and authority. In such traditions, the scripture is considered to be a sacred object that should be treated with the utmost respect and reverence.

5. **Talisman Role** : In some world religions, sacred texts are also used as talismans, which are objects believed to have magical or protective powers. This is often seen in traditions that view the scripture as the very word of God or as embodying divine power.

For example, in Islam, it is believed that reciting certain verses from the Quran can protect one from harm or danger. These verses are sometimes written on amulets or other objects and worn as a form of protection.

Similarly, in some Buddhist traditions, it is believed that carrying or wearing a text containing certain mantras or prayers can bring blessings or protect against negative forces. The use of sacred texts as talismans is often tied to specific cultural beliefs and practices and

may vary widely between different religious traditions. However, it is generally grounded in the idea that the sacred text is imbued with a special power or connection to the divine.

**Types of Religious Scripture**

In terms of the content and structure of religious scripture, we can broadly categorize them into two types: monotheistic and pantheistic.

Monotheistic scriptures refer to those religious texts that center around the belief in one God. These include texts such as the Bible (Judaism and Christianity), the Quran (Islam), and the Guru Granth Sahib (Sikhism). These texts often contain narratives of the relationship between God and humanity, moral teachings, and instructions for religious practices and rituals.

Pantheistic scriptures, on the other hand, refer to those texts that view God as a divine force that permeates everything in the universe. Examples of pantheistic scriptures include the Vedas and Upanishads (Hinduism), the Tao Te Ching (Taoism), and the Dhammapada (Buddhism). These texts often focus on the interconnectedness of all things and the pursuit of enlightenment or spiritual liberation. It is important to note, however, that these categories are not always mutually exclusive, and many religions may have elements of both monotheism and pantheism within their scripture. *(One example of a religion that incorporates both monotheistic and pantheistic elements within its scripture is Hinduism. In Hinduism, the concept of Brahman is both a transcendent and immanent force that pervades all of existence. This can be seen as a pantheistic element. At the same time, Hinduism also recognizes many deities, including a supreme godhead known as Brahman, which can be seen as a monotheistic element.)*

***Recommend Reading Materials***


- Van Voorst, Robert E. *Anthology of world scriptures*. Cengage Learning, 2016. Pp.1-20.
- Hardy, Grant. *Sacred texts of the world*. Teaching Company, 2014. Pp. 4-10.

# CHAPTER TWO

## Etymological Definition of Holy Bible, Scripture

The terms Bible, Scripture, Holy, and Sacred all have etymological roots that shed light on their meaning in religious contexts.

Bible: The term "Bible" comes from the Greek word "biblia," which means "books." The plural form of the word is used because the Bible is made up of multiple books, each of which is considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for Christian belief and practice. The word "biblia" itself comes from the word "biblion," which means "a scroll or papyrus document." In this sense, the term "Bible" refers to a collection of sacred writings that have been assembled into a single volume.

Scripture: The word "Scripture" comes from the Latin word "scriptura," which means "writing or the act of writing." The root of the word can be traced back to the Proto-Indo-European word "sker-" which means "to cut or separate." In religious contexts, the term "Scripture" refers to the written texts that are considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for faith and practice. The idea of Scripture as a source of authority has been central to many religious traditions throughout history, including Christianity, Judaism, and Islam.

The terms Bible and Scripture are often used interchangeably, but they have slightly different meanings and connotations.

The term "Bible" refers specifically to the collection of sacred writings that are considered authoritative for Christian belief and practice. The Bible is a compilation of 66 books, written over a period of thousands of years, by different authors, and in different languages. The books are grouped into two main sections: the Old Testament and the New Testament. The term "Bible" is used to describe this specific collection of books, and it is considered to be the primary source of authority for Christian belief and practice.

On the other hand, the term "Scripture" is more general and can refer to any sacred writing that is considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for religious belief and practice.

While the Bible is certainly a type of scripture, there are other scriptures in various religious traditions, such as the Quran in Islam or the Vedas in Hinduism.

In Christianity, the term "Scripture" is often used in a more general sense to refer to the entire body of sacred writings that are considered authoritative, including the Bible as well as other writings such as the Apocrypha. The term "Scripture" emphasizes the idea that these writings are considered to be divinely inspired and authoritative for faith and practice.

Overall, while the terms Bible and Scripture are related, the term Bible is more specific and refers to the particular collection of sacred writings that are considered authoritative for Christian belief and practice, while the term Scripture is more general and refers to any sacred writing that is considered authoritative for religious belief and practice.
The terms "Holy Bible" and "Holy Scripture" are both used to refer to the collection of sacred writings that are considered authoritative for Christian belief and practice. However, there are some differences in how the terms are used and what they emphasize.

The term "Holy Bible" specifically emphasizes the idea that this collection of writings is sacred and authoritative. The word "Bible" comes from the Greek word "biblia," which means "books" or "scrolls," and the term "Holy Bible" highlights the idea that these books are considered to be divinely inspired and authoritative for Christian belief and practice.

On the other hand, the term "Holy Scripture" is more general and can refer to any sacred writing that is considered authoritative for religious belief and practice. While the term "Holy Bible" specifically refers to the Christian scriptures, the term "Holy Scripture" can refer to the sacred writings of other religious traditions as well.

In practice, the terms "Holy Bible" and "Holy Scripture" are often used interchangeably, and both emphasize the idea that these writings are considered to be sacred and authoritative. However, the specific term used may depend on the context and the particular emphasis that the speaker or writer wishes to convey.

Holy: The word "holy" comes from the Old English word "halig," which means "consecrated or sacred." The root of the word can be traced back to the Proto-Germanic word "hailaga,"

which has the same meaning. In religious contexts, the term "holy" refers to something that is set apart for a sacred purpose. It can refer to people, objects, or places that are considered to be special or significant in a religious sense. In the context of the Bible, the term "holy" is often used to describe God or things that are associated with God, such as the Holy Spirit or the Holy Land.

Sacred: The word "sacred" comes from the Latin word "sacer," which means "holy or consecrated." The root of the word can be traced back to the Proto-Indo-European word "sak-", which means "to sanctify or make holy." In religious contexts, the term "sacred" refers to something that is considered to be special, significant, or worthy of reverence. It can refer to people, objects, or places that are associated with a particular religion or belief system. In the context of the Bible, the term "sacred" is often used to describe things that are considered to be set apart for a sacred purpose, such as the sacred vessels used in the temple or the sacred scriptures themselves.

In summary, the etymological meanings of these terms suggest that the Bible and Scripture are collections of sacred writings that are considered to be authoritative for religious belief and practice. The terms Holy and Sacred refer to things that are set apart for a sacred purpose and are associated with religious beliefs and practices. Understanding the etymology of these terms can help us to better understand their meaning in religious contexts and appreciate the significance that they hold for believers.

The etymology of the term "Holy Scripture" in the Orthodox Church can be understood by examining the origins of the words that make up the phrase.

The word "holy" comes from the Old English word "halig," which means "consecrated or sacred." The root of the word can be traced back to the Proto-Germanic word "hailaga," which has the same meaning. In the context of the Orthodox Church, the term "holy" refers to the sacred nature of the texts that make up Holy Scripture. These texts are considered to be the inspired word of God and are treated with reverence and respect.

The word "scripture" comes from the Latin word "scriptura," which means "writing or the act of writing." The root of the word can be traced back to the Proto-Indo-European word "sker-" which means "to cut or separate." In the context of the Orthodox Church, the term "scripture" refers to the written texts that make up Holy Scripture. These texts are considered to be the written record of God's interactions with humanity and reveal God's plan for the salvation of the world.

Together, the phrase "Holy Scripture" refers to the sacred writings that have been recognized by the Orthodox Church as authoritative and inspired. These writings are considered to be the ultimate source of authority for Christian belief and practice, and are understood to contain the revelation of God's plan for the salvation of humanity.

Holy Scripture, also known as the Bible, is the collection of sacred texts that form the foundation of Christian faith. It is a complex and multi-layered text that has been interpreted in many different ways throughout history. At its core, however, Holy Scripture is a record of God's interactions with humanity and his plan for the salvation of the world.

The definition of Holy Scripture has been the subject of much debate and discussion over the centuries. The concept of Holy Scripture has evolved over time, as different communities and traditions have grappled with questions of authority, interpretation, and inspiration.

For Christians, the definition of Holy Scripture is closely tied to the concept of canonization, which is the process by which certain texts were selected and recognized as authoritative and inspired. The canonization of Holy Scripture was a complex and contested process that took place over many centuries, and the resulting collection of texts varies somewhat between different Christian traditions.

Despite these differences, there are some key elements of the definition of Holy Scripture that are shared across all Christian traditions. These include the belief that Holy Scripture is the inspired word of God, that it reveals God's character and plan for the world, and that it is authoritative for Christian belief and practice.

In studying the definition of Holy Scripture, it is important to consider the historical and cultural context in which it was written, as well as the various interpretive approaches that have been used to understand it. By gaining a deeper understanding of the definition of Holy Scripture, students can gain a greater appreciation for the complexity and richness of this foundational text of Christian faith.
For the Orthodox Church, Holy Scripture is the collection of sacred texts that have been recognized by the Church as authoritative and inspired. These texts include the Old and New Testaments, as well as additional writings known as the deuterocanonical books, which are not accepted by all Christian traditions.

The Orthodox Church views Holy Scripture as the inspired word of God, containing the revelation of God's plan for the salvation of humanity. It is understood to be a product of both divine and human authorship, with the human authors being inspired by the Holy Spirit to write what they did. As such, the Orthodox Church believes that Holy Scripture is the ultimate source of authority for Christian belief and practice.

In addition to the written text of Holy Scripture, the Orthodox Church also recognizes the importance of tradition in interpreting and understanding the meaning of the Bible. Tradition is understood to be the collective wisdom and practice of the Church, which has been passed down through the ages and is guided by the Holy Spirit.

Overall, the definition of Holy Scripture for the Orthodox Church emphasizes the importance of both the written text and the interpretive tradition of the Church in understanding and living out the Christian faith.

**The Word of God**

The terms "Bible" and "The Word of God" are often used interchangeably, but they can have slightly different meanings depending on the context. The Bible is a specific collection of religious texts that are considered to be sacred by Christians. This collection includes 66 books in the Protestant tradition, and additional books in the Catholic and Orthodox traditions. The Bible is generally considered to be the inspired word of God, and is often used as a guide for moral and ethical behavior. On the other hand, "The Word of God" is a broader term that can refer to any message or communication that is believed to have come directly from God. In Christianity, the Word of God is often used to refer to the Bible as the primary source of God's message, but it can also refer to other forms of communication such as prophetic messages, personal revelation, or teachings passed down through tradition.

In essence, the Bible is one of the ways in which Christians understand and experience the Word of God, but it is not the only way. Christians believe that the Word of God can be communicated through various means, including prayer, personal experiences, and teachings from spiritual leaders. In summary, the Bible is a specific collection of religious texts that are considered to be the inspired word of God in Christianity. The Word of God is a broader term that can refer to any message or communication believed to have come directly from God, which can include the Bible but also other forms of communication.

**Here are some other common names for the Holy Bible:**

1. The Book of Books
2. The Good Book
3. The Holy Scriptures
4. The Old and New Testaments
5. The Gospel
6. The Living Word
7. The Sacred Writings
8. The Inspired Word
9. The Holy Word
10. The Book of Truth

## 1. The Book of Books

"The Book of Books" is a term that is sometimes used to refer to the Holy Bible. The term is meant to convey the idea that the Bible is the most important and influential book in human history, and that it serves as the foundation for many of the world's major religions.

The term "Book of Books" may also suggest that the Bible is a compilation of many different books, each with its own unique style, message, and purpose. The Bible contains 66 books in the Protestant tradition, and additional books in the Catholic and Orthodox traditions. These books were written by different authors over a span of thousands of years, yet they are all considered to be part of the same sacred text.

Overall, "The Book of Books" is a term that highlights the significance of the Bible as a timeless and influential work of literature and religious text.

Here are some additional meanings and interpretations of the term "The Book of Books":

- The most widely-read book in history: The Bible has been translated into hundreds of languages and has been read by billions of people throughout history. As such, it is often referred to as "The Book of Books" to highlight its unparalleled popularity and influence.
- The source of religious authority: For many believers, the Bible is the ultimate source of religious authority, providing guidance on matters of faith, morality, and ethics. As such, "The Book of Books" can be seen as a way of emphasizing the Bible's status as the primary text for understanding and interpreting religious doctrine.
- A reflection of human experience: The Bible is a complex and multifaceted text that includes a wide range of literary genres, including history, poetry, prophecy, and narrative. Some readers view the Bible as a reflection of the human experience, providing insights into the joys and sorrows, struggles and triumphs of human life.
- The story of God's relationship with humanity: Many believers view the Bible as a narrative that tells the story of God's relationship with humanity, from the creation of the world to the ultimate triumph of good over evil. As such, "The Book of Books"

can be seen as a way of highlighting the Bible's role as a central text in the spiritual lives of many believers.

Overall, "The Book of Books" is a term that reflects the diverse meanings and interpretations that people have ascribed to the Bible over the centuries. Whether viewed as a source of religious authority, a reflection of human experience, or a narrative of God's relationship with humanity, the Bible remains one of the most influential and widely-read books in the world.

2. **The Good Book**

"The Good Book" is a common nickname for the Holy Bible, and is used to express a sense of admiration and respect for the book. Here are a few possible interpretations of the term:

1. A book of moral and spiritual guidance: Many people refer to the Bible as "The Good Book" because they believe it contains valuable guidance for leading a moral and virtuous life. The Bible is full of teachings on love, compassion, forgiveness, and other virtues that are widely admired.
2. A book of comfort and hope: In times of difficulty or uncertainty, some people turn to the Bible for comfort and inspiration. The Bible contains many passages that offer hope and encouragement, and many believers find solace in its words.
3. A book of great literature: Even for those who are not religious, the Bible is often considered a masterpiece of literature. Its language, storytelling, and imagery have had a profound influence on Western culture, and many people appreciate the beauty and power of its words.
4. A book that has stood the test of time: The Bible has been read and revered for thousands of years, and has survived numerous challenges and criticisms throughout history. As such, "The Good Book" can be seen as a way of highlighting the Bible's enduring relevance and importance.

Overall, "The Good Book" is a term that can be interpreted in many different ways, but it generally reflects a sense of respect and admiration for the Bible's teachings, history, and enduring significance.

here are some additional interpretations of the term "The Good Book":

1. A source of wisdom: Many people view the Bible as a source of wisdom that can offer guidance on a wide range of issues, from personal relationships to social justice. The Bible is filled with stories and teachings that can be applied to modern life, and many people turn to it for advice and inspiration.
2. A book of miracles: The Bible contains many stories of miracles and divine interventions, such as the parting of the Red Sea or the healing of the blind. For many believers, these stories are evidence of God's power and presence in the world, and "The Good Book" can be seen as a way of acknowledging these miraculous events.
3. A book of redemption: The Bible tells the story of humanity's fall from grace and its subsequent redemption through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ. For many believers, "The Good Book" represents the ultimate story of forgiveness and redemption, and offers hope for a better future.
4. A book of community: The Bible has played a central role in many religious communities throughout history, and has helped to foster a sense of shared identity and purpose among believers. As such, "The Good Book" can be seen as a symbol of the bonds that unite believers in their faith.

Overall, "The Good Book" is a term that reflects the many different ways that people have interpreted and valued the Bible over the years. Whether viewed as a source of wisdom, a book of miracles, or a symbol of community, the Bible remains a cherished and influential text for many people around the world.

3. The Living Word

"The Living Word" is a term used to describe Jesus Christ, as well as the Bible as a whole. Here are some possible interpretations of the term:

1. A reference to Jesus Christ: In the Christian faith, Jesus is often referred to as "The Living Word," because he is seen as the embodiment of God's message to humanity. According to the Gospel of John, "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1). For many believers, Jesus represents the living expression of God's word, and his life and teachings are seen as a model for how to live a righteous and meaningful life.

2. A description of the Bible's power and relevance: The Bible is often referred to as "The Living Word" because its message continues to resonate with people of all backgrounds and cultures, even thousands of years after it was written. Many people believe that the Bible's teachings are still relevant today, and that it can provide guidance and comfort in times of need.
3. A reflection of God's ongoing presence in the world: For some believers, "The Living Word" represents the idea that God continues to speak to humanity through the Bible and through the teachings of Jesus. The Bible is seen as a living document that can provide new insights and revelations to those who study it with an open mind and heart.

Overall, "The Living Word" is a term that reflects the many different ways that people understand and value the Bible and the teachings of Jesus. Whether seen as a description of Jesus Christ, a reflection of the Bible's ongoing relevance, or a symbol of God's ongoing presence in the world, the term reflects the enduring power and influence of these spiritual concepts.

here are some additional interpretations of the term "The Living Word":

1. A description of the Bible's transformative power: For many believers, "The Living Word" refers to the idea that the Bible has the power to transform people's lives. The Bible is seen as a living, breathing text that can speak to people on a deeply personal level, and can inspire them to make positive changes in their lives.
2. A reference to the Holy Spirit: In some Christian traditions, "The Living Word" is seen as a way of describing the Holy Spirit, which is believed to be the ongoing presence of God in the world. The Holy Spirit is seen as a guiding force that can help people understand the Bible's message and apply it to their lives.
3. A symbol of God's ongoing revelation: For some believers, "The Living Word" represents the idea that God continues to reveal himself to humanity through the Bible and through other means. The Bible is seen as a living document that can help people understand God's ongoing work in the world, and can provide insights into the nature of God and his relationship to humanity.

Overall, "The Living Word" is a term that reflects the many different ways that people understand and interpret the Bible and its message. Whether seen as a transformative force, a

reflection of the Holy Spirit, or a symbol of God's ongoing revelation, the term highlights the idea that the Bible is a living, dynamic text that can continue to speak to people in new and meaningful ways.

4. **The Book of truth**

"The Book of Truth" and the "Holy Bible" are terms that are sometimes used interchangeably, but they can also have different meanings depending on the context and religious tradition in question. In general, "The Book of Truth" emphasizes the idea that the Bible contains the ultimate truth about God and His plan for humanity, while the "Holy Bible" is a broader term that simply refers to the collection of sacred texts that are considered authoritative by a particular religious tradition. However, some religious traditions may use the term "The Book of Truth" to refer to specific parts of the Bible or to specific prophecies within the Bible that are believed to reveal ultimate truth about God's plan for humanity. In this context, "The Book of Truth" may be seen as a subset of the larger collection of texts that make up the Holy Bible. Overall, both terms refer to the sacred texts that are central to various religious traditions and are considered to contain important teachings and revelations about God and the world.

In some religious traditions, "The Book of Truth" may also be used to refer to specific prophecies or revelations that are believed to be hidden or obscure within the Bible. For example, in the Catholic tradition, "The Book of Truth" is sometimes used to refer to the messages and prophecies that are claimed to have been received by a supposed end-time visionary named Maria Divine Mercy.

In other traditions, "The Book of Truth" may refer to other texts or teachings that are considered to be authoritative or divinely inspired. For example, in the Baha'i faith, the term "The Book of Truth" is used to refer to the writings of Baha'u'llah, the founder of the Baha'i faith, which are considered to be the final revelation from God to humanity.

Overall, while "The Book of Truth" and the "Holy Bible" are both terms that refer to sacred texts, their specific meanings and connotations can vary depending on the religious tradition in question. However, in general, both terms are used to emphasize the idea that the texts in question contain important teachings and revelations about God and His plan for humanity.

**What is Testament and Covenant?**

**The Meaning of Testament and Covenant?**

The terms "testament" and "covenant" have slightly different meanings but are often used interchangeably in reference to the Bible.

A "testament" refers to a legal document, often a will, that outlines a person's wishes for how their property and assets should be distributed after their death. In the context of the Bible, the Old Testament and the New Testament are sometimes referred to as the "Old Testament covenant" and the "New Testament covenant" respectively, reflecting the idea that each represents a new agreement or covenant between God and humanity.

A "covenant" is a binding agreement or contract between two parties. In the Bible, the term is often used to describe the relationship between God and his people. The Old Testament contains several covenants between God and various individuals or groups, such as the covenant with Noah (Genesis 9:8-17), the covenant with Abraham (Genesis 17:1-22), and the covenant with Moses and the Israelites (Exodus 19-24). These covenants involved promises from God and obligations on the part of the people.

The New Testament presents Jesus as the mediator of a new covenant between God and humanity, which is based on faith in Jesus as the Messiah and his death and resurrection. This new covenant is described in several places in the New Testament, including in the Gospels (Matthew 26:28, Mark 14:24, Luke 22:20) and in the letters of Paul (e.g. 2 Corinthians 3:6, Hebrews 8:6-13). It is sometimes referred to as the "New Covenant" to distinguish it from the covenants of the Old Testament.

Overall, the terms "testament" and "covenant" both refer to the idea of a binding agreement or contract between God and his people, and they help to emphasize the continuity and development of God's relationship with humanity throughout history.

The terms "testament" and "covenant" are often used interchangeably in reference to the Bible, but they have slightly different meanings.

A "testament" refers to a legal document, often a will, that outlines a person's wishes for how their property and assets should be distributed after their death. In the context of the Bible, the Old Testament and the New Testament are sometimes referred to as the "Old Testament covenant" and the "New Testament covenant" respectively, reflecting the idea that each represents a new agreement or covenant between God and humanity.

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## Chapter 3: Divine Inspiration and Revelation

The objective of Lesson three is to explore the concept of Divine Inspiration and Revelation within the context of the Orthodox Christian Tradition.

**By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:**

- Define the terms *Divine Inspiration* and *Revelation*, and explain their importance in Orthodox Theology and Spirituality.

- Distinguish between different types of revelation (e.g. verbal, written, direct, indirect, etc.) and explain their significance in Orthodox theology.

- Reflect on their own experiences of prayer and discernment and consider how they relate to the Orthodox concept of Divine Inspiration and Revelation.

***Recommend Reading Materials***

- Ewert, David. *A general introduction to the Scripture: From ancient tablets to modern translations*. Zondervan, 2010.

**Definition of Divine Revelation**

The English word revelation comes from the Latin *"revelo"* or from Hebrew *"galah"* or from the Greek *"apokalypto"* which is mean to uncover and to unveil something hidden, so that it may be seen and known for what it is. Accordingly when the Holy Scripture speaks of revelation the thought intended is of God the creator actively disclosing to men His power and glory, nature and character, will, way, plans, and in short himself in order that men may know him. The revelation in both testaments is a wide one covering the ideas of making: obscure things clear, bringing hidden things to light, showing signs, speaking words and causing the persons addressed to see, hear, perceive, understand and know. The concept of revelation lies at the heart of the Christian faith. We believe that God has uniquely revealed Himself to humanity in the arena of human history. We believe that God chose to reveal Himself to us and Christianity is a response to God's self-disclosure in history. It is important to note that the content of revelation is not information or data, but God Himself. It is a self-revelation, self-disclosure, not revelation about things or ideas. God is the one who revealed himself and, Holy Scripture tells us towards that revelation.

In Orthodox Christianity, divine revelation is understood as the way in which God reveals himself and his will to humanity. It is through divine revelation that humanity is able to know and understand God's plan for creation, and it is considered essential for the salvation of humanity.

Orthodox Christians believe that divine revelation is a continuing process that began with the creation of the world and continues through the present day. This revelation is seen in both

the natural world and in the Scriptures, which are considered to be a record of God's revelation throughout history. Divine revelation is also seen in the life of the Church, particularly in the sacraments, which are considered to be visible signs of God's grace. The teachings of the Church Fathers and the decisions of Church councils are also seen as part of the ongoing process of divine revelation. Overall, divine revelation is seen as a gift from God that allows humanity to know and understand him, and it is the responsibility of the Church to preserve and interpret this revelation for future generations.

**Purpose of Revelation**

The purpose of divine revelation in Orthodox Christianity is to enable humanity to know and understand God's plan for creation, as well as to provide guidance and direction for the lives of believers. Through divine revelation, God reveals his character, attributes, and will to humanity, allowing us to better understand our place in the world and our relationship with God. The revelation of God's plan and purpose for creation is intended to lead us to repentance, faith, and obedience to God, ultimately leading to salvation and union with God.

Divine revelation is also intended to provide guidance and direction for believers in their daily lives. Through the teachings of the Church, the Scriptures, and the guidance of the Holy Spirit, believers are able to discern God's will and live in a manner that is pleasing to him. Divine revelation also provides comfort, hope, and encouragement in times of difficulty or trial, as believers are able to draw upon the promises and truths revealed in Scripture and through the life of the Church. Overall, the purpose of divine revelation is to reveal God's character, will, and plan for humanity, and to provide guidance and direction for believers in their journey of faith.

**The Necessity of Revelation**

The Scripture assumes throughout that God must first disclose himself before men can know him. The Aristotelian idea of an inactive God whom man can discover by following out an argument is quite unscriptural. A revelatory initiative is needed, first, because God is transcendent. He is so far from man in his mode of being that man cannot see him (Jn. 1:18, Tim. 6:16. Ex. 33:20), nor find him out by searching (cf. Jb. 11:7, 23:3-9), nor read his thoughts by shrewd guesswork (Is.55:8f). Now, however, there is a second reason why man's knowledge of God must depend on God's revelatory initiative. His powers of perception in

the realm of divine things have been so dulled by Satan (2 Cor. 4:4) and sin (cf. 1 Cor. 2:14), and his mind is so prepossessed by his own fancied wisdom which runs contrary to the true knowledge of God (Rom. 1:2I, 1 Cor. 1:21), that it is beyond his natural powers to apprehend God, however presented to him. In fact according to St. Paul God presents himself constantly to every man through his works of creation and providence (Rom. l:19, Acts 14:17, Ps. 19:1).

Generally speaking Revelation has two local points: God's purposes and God's person. This is mean: A). on the one hand, God tells men about himself who he is, what he has done, what he is doing, and will do, and what he requires them to do. Thus he took Noah, Abraham and Moses in to his confidence, telling them what he had planned and what their part in his plan was to be (Gen. 6:13-21, 12:1, Gen15:13-21, 17:15-21,18:l7, Ex. 3:7-22). Again, he declared to Israel the laws and promises of his covenant (Ex. 20-23, Dt. 4:13, 28, Ps. 78:5, 147:19). He disclosed his purpose to the prophets (Am. 3:7). Jesus Christ told his disciples 'all that I have heard from my father' (Jn. 15:15), and promised them the Holy Spirit to complete his work of instructing them (Jn. 16:21). God revealed to Paul the 'mystery' of his eternal purpose in Christ (Ephe.1;9, 3:3- 11. From this stand point, as God's own precise disclosure of his saving purpose and work, Paul calls the gospel 'the truth', in contrast with, error and falsehood (2Thes. 2:1 1-13, 2Tim. 2: I8). Hence the use of the phrase 'revealed truth' in Christian theology to denote what God has told men about himself.

B. On the other hand, when God sends men his word, he also confronts them with himself. The Scripture does not think of revelation as a mere broadcasting of information, but as God's personal coming to individuals to make himself known to them (Gen. 35:7; Ex. 6:3).

**The Scriptural process of Divine Revelation**

God spoke to the prophets in many and varies ways (Heb. 1:1, Num. 12:6). The following are the different ways that God has revealed to humankind.

1. He spoke to prophets by angels, as he did to Lot (Gen. 19)
2. In dreams as he did to Daniel (Dan. 7:1)
3. In visions as he did with Isaiah and Ezekiel (Isa. 1:1, Eze. 1:1)
4. By using miracles eg. Moses and the burning bush (Ex. 3:2)
5. Nature was used to speak to the Psalmist (Ps. 19:1)
6. Sometimes God spoke in an audible voice (I Sam. 3:4)

7. The inner voice of the individual's conscience and communion with God
8. The priests discovered the will of God by means of the Urim and Thumim (Ex. 28:30, Num.27:21)
9. Causing lots was designated as a means by which God indicated his will (Prov. I6:33)

In Orthodox Christianity, divine revelation is seen as necessary for several reasons:

1. To reveal God's character and nature: Without divine revelation, humanity would have no way of knowing or understanding God's character and nature. Through divine revelation, God reveals his love, mercy, justice, and other attributes, allowing us to know him more fully.
2. To reveal God's plan for creation: Without divine revelation, humanity would be left to guess at the purpose and meaning of life. Through divine revelation, God reveals his plan for creation, including the salvation of humanity through Jesus Christ.
3. To provide guidance and direction: Without divine revelation, believers would have no way of knowing how to live in a manner that is pleasing to God. Through the Scriptures and the teachings of the Church, believers are able to discern God's will and live in a manner that is consistent with his plan and purpose.
4. To provide comfort and hope: Without divine revelation, believers would be left to face the difficulties and trials of life without any assurance of God's presence or care. Through divine revelation, believers are able to draw upon the promises and truths revealed in Scripture and through the life of the Church, providing comfort, hope, and encouragement in times of difficulty.

Overall, the necessity of divine revelation is rooted in humanity's need to know and understand God, his plan for creation, and how to live in a manner that is pleasing to him. Without divine revelation, humanity would be left without guidance or direction and would be unable to fulfill our purpose as created beings.

**Inspiration**

Inspiration is a term which drives from Lateen “inspirer” means “two breath upon or into something. Some Scholars understand the word inspiration as referring to the spirits action in the lives of Scriptural writers such as the prophets, apostles and others, so that what the writes become the word of Guard as the basis of this understanding the scholars appeal to texts which speak of Gods profits resaving message from the Lord which the subserviently rout

down Ger 36: 1-2, Eze, 11: 5, Mic. 3:8,2pet, 1:21,). Other Scholars build form the Pauline declaration, "All scriptures is inspired by God" (2 Tim 3:15). Based on this they assert that "inspiration" refers to a quality of the Scriptural writings themselves. Generally one could distinguish within the one act of inspiration as an active sense ( the action of God), and a passive sense (the effect of god's action on the human author). In keeping with in this distinction we may define "inspiration" as primarily an activity, and secondarily as a deposit or effect writings.

Inspiration as applied to the Scripture refers to the God given authority of its teaching for the thought and life of the believer, inspiration in the Scripture approaches in double authorship" God is the author of the Scripture (not mean He dictates it or written it but it means he willed it into existence), and God is the originator.

**Inspiration in the Old Testament**

It is true that there is no explicit mention inspiration in the page of the Old Testament. However, there are many passages which hint at it. We learn, for example, that it was God who has caused Mosses to record certain events and laws (ex. 17:14, 24:: 3-4,;34: 27). Hence it may be supposed that written texts existed and were attributed to mosses and ultimately to God's authority. We also find references to prophets writing down the word of the Lord which they had received (Isa.30:8, Jer. 30: 2, 36: 2, Hab. 2:2). Such writing had a special claim to be considered sacred and to be regarded as the word of God. The people of the Old Testament believed that God guided them through his spirit. The action of the spirit is .seen in different ways in the Old Testament. In the first place there is an inspiration to act (Judges 3:10) and an inspiration to speak, especially in the case of the prophets (2 Sam 23:2; Isa. 59:21; Ez. I 1:5). Then (here is an inspiration to write (Ex. 1 7:14). Thus we come to three forms of inspiration. The inspiration to act may be described as pastoral inspiration: which moved the pastors or leaders of the people ol God. Then there is prophetic inspiration, enjoyed by the speakers of the word: prophets and apostles. Finally comes scriptural inspiration, the prolongation end completion of the other two. All three together form what we might describe as Scriptural inspiration.

**Inspiration in the New Testament**

There are two most important texts in the New Testament (2 Tim. 3:16-17 and 2 Pet. 1:20-21), which with reference to the Old Testament, consider respectively the extent and the

nature of inspiration. 2 Tim 3:16-11: **"All scripture (pasa graphe) is inspires by God (theopneustos) and profitable for reaching, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work".** The Greek expression 'pasa graphe: most likely means 'every passage of scripture. The Greek adjective theopneustos is composed of theos, from theos,' "'God", and pneustos, from pneo, "to breathe", it is generally understood in the passive sense, meaning that the scripture is "breathed out by God", "God breathed"', that is, the scripture is the product of the creative breath of God. In other words, what is declared by this important passage is that the Scriptural books are a divine product, without indicating how God has operated in producing them. In the Scripture, the "breath of God" is the symbol of his almighty power, which is expressed through his creative word. In Ps. 33:6 we read: "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, their entire host by the breath of his mouth". Here God's breath is seen as the irresistible outflow of his power. When Paul declares that every scripture is the product of the divine breath; he asserts that scripture is the product of a specifically divine operation. The spirit in the Old Testament is the creative power of God as expressed in the lives and words of Israel's great prophets. Hence 2 Tim would be affirming that every passage in The Old Testament is God-breathed, or inspired; as a consequence these scriptures are useful for leaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness.

2 Pet 1:19-21:

**'And we have the prophetic word made more sure. You will do well to pay attention to this as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in our hearts. First of all you must understand this that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation, because no prophecy ever came by the impulse of man. but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God.'**

What Paul tells us about the divine origin of the scripture is confirmed and complemented by 2 Pet 1:19-21. In this letter the author is confronting the troublemaking false teachers who claim that the traditional teachings about Jesus' Parousia are not heavenly revelations but only human creations (cf. 2 Pet 3:1-4; 1:16). Peter is assuring his readers that what had been known to them of "The power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ" (2 pet 1:16b) was not based on cleverly devised myth (1:16a). He gives them the testimony of eyewitnesses of Christ's glory (l: 16c-18). Then he tells them that they have better testimony than even that of

eyewitnesses. "We have the prophetic word"; and this, he says, is "more sure", and therefore should certainly be heeded. The reason why every prophecy of scripture should be heeded to is that it does not come "'by the impulse of man"; that is, it is not the result' of human investigation nor the product of the writer's own thinking, but it is the result of God's action.

**Support for the Scriptural claim of Inspiration**

There are two lines of evidence to be considered on the inspiration of the Scripture: the evidence flowing from within scripture (internal evidence) and that coming from outside (external evidence).

**Internal evidence**

The Holy Scripture claims to be and proves to be the word of God. There are general claims for the Scripture as whole and more specific claims for scripture and even individual books. This is true of both Old and New Testaments. Support for Holy Scripture's claim to be the written word of God comes from many sources. First, from the very nature of the Scripture, it gives every appearance of having come from God. Second, the witness of the spirit to the heart of the believer adds further confirmation to the Holy Scripture's inspiration. Third, the transforming ability of scripture is indication of its divine origin. Fourth, the very unity of the Scripture itself is another internal evidence for the inspiration of the Scripture.

Internal evidences are found within the Scripture itself and include:

1. **Unity of the Scripture:** Despite being written over a periods of time by different authors from various backgrounds, the Scripture exhibits a remarkable unity of message and purpose.
2. **Fulfilled Prophecies:** There are many prophecies in the Scripture that were fulfilled hundreds of years later, which suggests that the Scripture is not merely a human book but one that was inspired by God.
3. **Christological Unity:** The Old Testament points forward to the coming of the Messiah, and the New Testament reveals that Jesus is that Messiah. This Christological unity throughout the Scripture suggests that it is not merely a human book, but one that was inspired by God.

**External evidence**

The internal evidence of inspiration is mostly subjective in nature. It relates to what the believer sees or senses in his experience with the Scripture. All the internal evidences are available only inside Christianity. The non-believers does not sense the witness of the Holy 'Spirit, nor experience the edifying power of scripture in their life. Unless he steps by lath to the inside, these internal evidences may have convincing effect on his life. This is where the external evidence plays a crucial role. It indicates where the 'inside' really is. The following are the external evidences.

1. **Evidence from the historicity of the Scripture**: much of the Scripture is historical and as such is subject to historical investigation. The most significant area of confirmation in this regard has conies from the field of archaeology. The renowned archaeologist William F. Albright said, "There can be no doubt that archaeology has confirmed the substantial historicity of the Old Testament tradition." Nelson Gluek adds, "It may be stated categorically that no archaeological discovery has ever controvert a Scriptural reference. Scores of archaeological findings have been made which confirm in clear outline or exact detail historical statements in the Scripture." Clifford A. Wilson has added still more support to the historical reliability of the Scripture. No historical discovery is a direct evidence of any spiritual claim in the Scripture, such as the claim to be divinely inspired; nevertheless the historicity of the Scripture does provide indirect verification of the claim of inspiration.
2. **Evidence from prophecy**: another forceful external testimony to the inspiration of scripture is the fact of fulfilled prophecy. According to mosses, "a prophet was false if he made predictions that were never fulfilled" (deut. 18) No unconditional prophecy of the Scripture about events to the present day has gone unfilled. Hundreds of predictions, some of them given. Hundreds of years in advance, have been literally fulfilled. The time (Dan. 9:25). The city (Mic. 5:2). And nature (Isa. 7:14) of Christ's birth were foretold in the Old Testament, as were dozens of other things about his life, death, and resurrection (lsa.'53). Numerous other prophecies have been fulfilled, including the destruction of Edom (Obad. J), the curse on Babylon (Isa. 13), the destruction of Tyre (Eze. 26). And Neneveh (Neh. 1-3) and the return of Israel to the Land (Isa. 11:11). Other books claim divine inspiration, such as Quran, the book of Mermon and parts of the veda. But none those books contains predictive prophecy. As a result, fulfilled prophecy is a strong indication of the unique, divine authority of the Scripture.

3. **Evidence from the influence of the Scripture**: no book has' been more widely disseminated and has more broadly influenced the course of world events than office Scripture. The Scripture has been translated into more languages, been published in more copies, influenced more thought, inspired more art, and motivated more discoveries than any other book in history. The Scripture has been translated into over many languages representing more than ninety percent of the world's population.
4. **Evidence from the apparent indestructibility of the Scripture:** despite its importance, the Scripture has suffered more vicious attacks than would be expected to be made on such a book. But the Scripture has withstood ail its attackers. Scriptural critics once regarded much of it as mythological, but archaeology has established it as historical. Antagonists have attacked its leaching as primitive, but moralists urge that its teaching on love be applied to modern society. Skeptics have cast doubt on its authenticity, and yet more men are convinced of its truth today than ever. An attack on the Scripture continues to arise from science, psychology, and political movements, but the Scripture remains undaunted. The Scripture remains just as strong after the attack. Jesus said, "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Mark 13:31).
5. **Evidence from miracles**: another support for the inspiration of scripture comes from miracles. A miracle is an act of God and confirms the word of God by a prophet of God. The Scripture is a prophetic book. Every book in it was written by a prophet or apostle. And since there were miracles to confirm the prophetic message given by authors of scripture, then the Scripture is confirmed to be the word of God by acts of God (miracles).

**The Relation between Inspiration and Revelation**

Revelation concerns the origin of truth (1 Cor. 2:10). Revelation involves disclosure rather than discovery. Revelation refers to the divine disclosure of the scripture. Sometimes it can be a disclosure of a person (Christ). Even though the two concepts (inspiration and revelation) are interrelated in the total process of God's communication, they are quite distinguishable. God revealed truth to men who received and recorded it; and Inspiration becomes the means God. Used to achieve His revelation in the Scripture. Inspiration involves man in an active sense, whereas revelation is solely the activity of God. Interpretation focuses on the apprehension and understanding of the truth. In revelation God unveils truth; by

interpretation man understands that truth. The three concepts (inspiration, revelation, and interpretation) (bun three necessary links in the communication chain "from God to us”

- Revelation is the fact of divine communication

- Inspiration is the means of divine communication

## Chapter 5:
## The Canon of Scripture in Orthodox Church

This Lesson is an introduction to the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church. The lesson explore the historical development of the canon, the role of the canon in Orthodox Theology and practice, and the differences between the Orthodox, Catholic, and Protestant canons of Scripture.

**At the end of this lesson, students will be able to:**

- Provide an overview of the development of the Scriptural canon in the Orthodox Church, including the criteria used to determine which books were accepted and which were rejected.
- Examine the role of Tradition in the formation of the Scriptural canon, including the importance of the writings of the Church Fathers and Early Christians.
- Explore the theological and practical implications of the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church.
- Compare and contrast the canon of Scripture in the Orthodox Church with other Christian traditions, such as the Catholic and Protestant canons.

***Recommend Reading Materials***

- Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part III

- The Eastern Church never conclusively defined a canon of Scripture in an authoritative statement such as those ultimately pronounced in the West.

- The most unusual aspect of the canon of Scripture among the Orthodox is that no official canon exists at all and the canon remains somewhat loose.
- The word “canon” (kanon in Greek) originally meant a reed or measuring stick. It came to mean the applicable standard for measurement: a ruler. The word “canon” was employed to refer to a rule or Church law. With respect to the Bible, “canon” is the list of books recognized as authoritative Scripture because when deciding which books should be considered Scripture, the Church applied certain standards. The canon of Scripture also demarcates those books which may be read in Church.
- Although some Orthodox Christians refer to these additional books as “deutero-canonicals” for ease of reference, strictly speaking that term is a Catholic designation. For the Orthodox, no such differentiation has ever been made between the “deutero-canonicals” and other books.
- By the late second century, the increased distance from the time of the apostles prompted Christians to think differently about apostolic books. The actions of Marcion and Tatian also contributed toward the creation of a Christian canon. Marcion, a presbyter from Asia, had entirely rejected three of the gospels—Matthew, Mark and John—and had created his own highly edited version of Luke. Tatian, a Syrian Christian, had blended all four into one large gospel in the Syriac language which was dubbed Diatessaron (“through four”), which became very popular among Syrians. But most Christians decried the mutilation of the apostolic writings. Prominent figures such as Tertullian and Irenaeus vigorously protested the activities of Marcion and Tatian in their books and condemned all tampering with written apostolic testimony.
- The mutilation and adulteration of apostolic writings awakened Christians and compelled them to realize that apostolic books were also inspired Holy Scripture to be preserved and protected.
- Pseudonymous and apocryphal books also mushroomed, both in an effort to promote divergent theologies and to preserve earlier oral traditions. Dogmatic questions also pressed upon the Church as heresies took hold and began to threaten orthodox Christianity. A New Testament canon was needed.
- Four criteria of canonicity for New Testament books: apostolicity, orthodoxy, antiquity, and usage.

- **Apostolicity:** The criterion of apostolicity relies on succession from Christ to the Apostles, and from the latter to the ecclesiastical authority. A text composed by an apostle, or a figure associated with an apostle, was reckoned as canonical. Among the four canonical Gospels, two are attributed to the apostles Matthew and John. The other two are ascribed to Mark, and Luke who are respectively linked with Peter and Paul. On the other hand, if it was believed that a text was not written by an apostle or someone associated with an apostle it was excluded from the canon.
- **Orthodoxy:** It was not enough to ascertain a book's apostolicity. If that were the case, many more books, Gospels, Acts, Epistles, and Apocalypses would have been included in the New Testament. For recognition, the text was tested against the "rule of faith." Be that as it may, there are cases where this criterion becomes limited. Without denying the existence of a minimum consensus concerning the person of Christ and his redemptive role.
- **Antiquity:** The criterion of antiquity would exclude a book believed to have been composed afetr the period of the Apostles.
- **Use:** If a text is constantly read, interpreted, and used in worship by the majority of important Christian communities, it had a chance of being recognized as canonical.

- The available evidence for the emergence of Old Testament (OT) and New Testament (NT) canons comes from church father citations, canon lists, local church councils, surviving scriptural manuscripts, and translations of the ancient Jewish and Christian religious texts.
- In antiquity the notion of "canon" (Grk., kanw/n) was initially and regularly understood as measurements, guidelines, or rules to follow whether in art, architecture, philosophy, rhetoric, or poetry, and models to be followed in writing. Te notion came also to be used of the Church's regula fdei, that is as guidelines for faith and conduct. Tese canons for faith and conduct were always rooted in the Church's earliest traditions of and about Jesus and their implications for faith, mission, and conduct (McDonald 2017a:76–117). Te notion of holding fast to "what we have attained" in Phil 3:16 is at the heart of "canon" tradition. Tough this text does not use kanon, it is a "rule" like we see in Gal 6:16, that is, a "rule" of faith or boundaries or

limitations as in 2 Cor 10:13, 15–16. In the fourth century, Athanasius, following earlier Hellenistic Alexandrian models, used “canon” to identify a specifc collection of authoritative scriptural books.

- **Introduction**. We need to recollect here that the Bible is comprised of sixty-six books written by approximately 40 authors over a period of 1600 years. 1. The term “canon,” comes from the Greek word kanèn, kan¯on, meaning a rule, a standard, hence a measure of authoritative teaching. Compare the use of this same Greek word in Galatians 6:16. 2. The “canon of Scripture” is that recognized and accepted collection of sixty-six books of the Bible which conforms to a standard, especially that of being God-breathed or inspired (II Tim. 3:16), and consequently is infallible, that is truthful and without error. 3. To say that the Scriptures are “canonical” is to declare that they have been recognized as the Word of God written, and thus have accepted authority which is unique, that is distinct from all other books. 4. When the Old Testament and New Testament canons were recognized as complete, it was not man determining the parameters of the Word of God, but rather man identifying the Word of God.

**Canon**

Learn diligently, and from the Church, what are the books of the Old Testament, and what those of the New. And, please, read none of the apocryphal writings. For why you, who do not know those which are acknowledged among all, trouble yourself in vain about those which are disputed? Read the divine Scriptures, the twenty-two books of the Old Testament, these that have been translated by the Seventy-two Interpreters. Cyrils of Jerusalem, Lecture 4: Of the Divine Scriptures 33

- The English word “canon” derives from the Greek term kanōn. Most interestingly, kanōn is a word which the Greek took from Hebrew qāneh, “cane stick” (having behind it the Akkadian qanūm, with the same basic meaning). The ancient Greek polis used the word kanōn to designate the ideas of “accuracy” (akribeia) and “truth” (alētheia) in politics and arts (sculpture, music). In the New Testament, the word “canon” has a general connotation of “spiritual norm or standard” (Gal 6:16). This general meaning of “norm” or “rule” can be also found in a mid-first century c.e. Jewish work written by a Pharisee, 4 Macc 7:21 (author’s translation): “Philosophizing on the whole rule (kanona) of philosophy.

**Chapter 6:**

**The Language and Versions of the Scripture**

This Lesson provides an overview of the various languages and versions of the Scripture, including their history, development, and translations. The Lesson explores about the major languages in which the Scripture was originally written, such as Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek, as well as the different versions that have been produced throughout history. They will also explore the challenges and opportunities involved in translating the Scripture from one language to another.

**At the end of this lesson, students will be able to:**

- Understand the history and development of the major languages in which the Scripture was written.
- Understand the various versions of the Scripture that have been produced throughout history.
- Appreciate the challenges and opportunities involved in translating the Scripture from one language to another.
- Equip with the skills necessary to critically evaluate different translations of the Scripture.

***Recommend Reading Materials***

- Packer, J. I., John Piper, R. Kent Hughes, Leland Ryken, Vern S. Poythress, John D. Currid, Peter J. Gentry et al. *"Understanding Scripture: An Overview of the Scripture's Origin, Reliability, and Meaning."* (2012).

Understanding the languages and versions of the Scripture is important for several reasons:

**Interpretation**: Understanding the original languages in which the Scripture was written can help us to better understand the meaning and context of the text. Each language has its own unique vocabulary, grammar, and syntax, and understanding these nuances can help us to more accurately interpret the meaning of the text.

**Translation**: With so many different translations of the Scripture available, it is important to be able to critically evaluate the accuracy and faithfulness of each translation. Understanding the challenges and opportunities involved in translating the Scripture can help us to choose the best translation for our needs.

**Cultural context:** The Scripture was written in a specific cultural context, and understanding this context is crucial for interpreting and applying the text in our own lives. By understanding the cultural context in which the text was written, we can better understand the meaning and significance of the text for our own lives and contexts.

**History**: Understanding the history and development of the different versions of the Scripture can help us to appreciate the significance of the text and the impact it has had on society and culture throughout history.

**Theology**: Understanding the original languages and the different translations of the Scripture is crucial for developing sound theological doctrines and beliefs. Theology is talking about God and His nature as revelation, and accurate interpretation of the text is necessary for sound theology.

**Scholarship**: For scholars and researchers in the field of Scriptural studies, understanding the languages and versions of the Scripture is essential for their work. Scholars rely on their knowledge of the original languages to analyze and interpret the text, and they often consult multiple translations in order to gain a broader understanding of the text.

**Missionary work**: For missionaries working in foreign countries, understanding the languages and versions of the Scripture is critical for their work. Missionaries must be able to communicate the message of the Scripture in a way that is clear and understandable to people who speak different languages and come from different cultural backgrounds.

**Personal growth**: Finally, understanding the languages and versions of the Scripture is important for personal growth and spiritual development. By studying the original languages and consulting different translations, we can gain a deeper understanding of the text and apply it to our own lives in meaningful ways. This can lead to greater spiritual growth and a stronger relationship with God.

Overall, understanding the languages and versions of the Scripture is important for accurately interpreting and applying the text to our own lives and contexts. It can also help us to appreciate the significance of the text and its impact on society and culture throughout history.

## II. **The Major Languages of the Scripture**

The Scripture was originally written in three major languages: Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek. Each of these languages has a unique history and context that is important to understand for accurate interpretation of the text. In this section, we will explore each of these languages in more detail, including their history, development, and significance for the Scripture.

### Hebrew

#### History and development of the Hebrew language

The Hebrew language has a long and complex history that can be traced back to the 12th century BCE. It was originally spoken by the Israelites, a group of Semitic people who lived in the ancient Near East. The earliest written records of the Hebrew language are found in the Hebrew Scripture, which is also known as the Old Testament.

The Hebrew language continued to evolve and change over time. During the Babylonian exile, which occurred from 586-539 BCE, many Israelites were taken captive and brought to Babylon. During this time, the Hebrew language was influenced by Aramaic, which was the dominant language of the Babylonian Empire. As a result, the Hebrew language adopted some Aramaic words and grammatical structures.

After the Babylonian exile, the Hebrew language continued to develop. During the Second Temple period, which lasted from 516 BCE to 70 CE, the Hebrew language was used for religious and literary purposes. The Dead Sea Scrolls, which were discovered in the mid-20th century, provide important examples of Hebrew texts from this time period.

During the middle Ages, Hebrew was used as a literary and scholarly language among Jewish communities in Europe and the Middle East. Hebrew texts from this time period include commentaries on the Hebrew Scripture, works of Jewish philosophy, and mystical texts. In the 19th century, the Jewish movement for national revival led to a renewed interest in Hebrew as a spoken language. Hebrew was used as the language of instruction in Jewish schools, and a number of Hebrew-language newspapers and literary journals were established.

Today, Hebrew is the official language of the State of Israel and is spoken by millions of people around the world. Modern Hebrew is based on the grammar and vocabulary of Scriptural Hebrew, but it also includes many new words and expressions that have been

added to the language over time. The development of the Hebrew language over thousands of years is a testament to its resilience and adaptability.

## Significance of the Hebrew language for the Old Testament and New Testament

The Hebrew language has great significance for both the Old Testament and New Testament of the Scripture.

The Old Testament was written primarily in Hebrew, with some portions of the text also written in Aramaic. Hebrew was the language of the Israelites, and it was the language in which the Jewish Scriptures were originally composed. The Hebrew language was an important part of the Jewish religious tradition and was used for religious purposes, including the study and interpretation of the Hebrew Scripture.

The Hebrew language is particularly important for understanding the Old Testament because it provides insights into the original meaning of the text. Hebrew is a rich and complex language, with many nuances and layers of meaning that are difficult to capture in translation. By studying the Hebrew text of the Old Testament, scholars are able to gain a deeper understanding of the original meaning of the text, including its cultural and historical context.

The New Testament, on the other hand, was written primarily in Greek, with some portions of the text also written in Aramaic. Greek was the language of the Roman Empire, which had conquered much of the Mediterranean world at the time of the New Testament's composition. Greek was also the language of commerce and trade, making it a practical choice for a text that was meant to be read and circulated widely.

However, even though the New Testament was written in Greek, it still contains many references to the Hebrew Scriptures. Many of the ideas and themes in the New Testament are based on the Jewish religious tradition, and the authors of the New Testament frequently quoted from the Hebrew Scriptures to support their arguments. Understanding the Hebrew language and the Jewish religious tradition is therefore important for understanding the context and meaning of the New Testament.

In summary, the Hebrew language is significant for the Old Testament because it was the language in which the text was originally composed and provides insights into the original meaning of the text. The Greek language is significant for the New Testament because it was

the language in which the text was originally composed and was a practical choice for a text meant to be circulated widely, but understanding the Hebrew language and the Jewish religious tradition is also important for understanding the context and meaning of the New Testament.

**Key Feature of Hebrew Language**

The Hebrew language is a Semitic language that has a number of unique features that distinguish it from other languages. Here are some key features of the Hebrew language:

**The Hebrew alphabet:** The Hebrew language is written using the Hebrew alphabet, which consists of 22 consonants and no vowels. Vowels are represented by diacritical marks placed above or below the consonants. This system of writing can be challenging for learners of Hebrew, as it requires them to memorize a new set of characters and to become proficient in recognizing and using the vowel diacritics.

**The root system**: Hebrew words are constructed using a root system, in which a basic three-letter root is combined with various prefixes, suffixes, and vowel patterns to form words with different meanings. For example, the root k-t-b (כְּתַב) means "to write", and by adding different prefixes, suffixes, and vowel patterns, we can create words such as kitav (כְּתָבָה) "writing" or kotev (כּוֹתֵב) "writer".

**Gender and number:** Hebrew nouns and adjectives have gender (masculine or feminine) and number (singular or plural) endings, which can change depending on the context. For example, the word for "house" is bayit (בַּיִת), which is masculine singular, but the word for "houses" is batim (בָּתִּים), which is masculine plural.

**Verbs**: Hebrew verbs have a complex system of tenses, moods, and voices, which can be challenging for learners to master. In addition, Hebrew verbs are conjugated based on the gender and number of the subject, and can also have prefixes and suffixes added to them to indicate aspects such as causation or reciprocity.

Scriptural Hebrew vs. Modern Hebrew: Scriptural Hebrew, the form of Hebrew used in the Old Testament, has some significant differences from Modern Hebrew, the form of Hebrew used in modern-day Israel. Scriptural Hebrew is characterized by archaic vocabulary, complex grammatical constructions, and a greater reliance on the root system, while Modern

Hebrew has simplified grammar and vocabulary and incorporates many loanwords from other languages.

In summary, the Hebrew language has a unique alphabet, a root system for constructing words, complex grammar with gender and number endings, complex verb tenses, and has evolved over time from Scriptural Hebrew to Modern Hebrew. Understanding these key features is essential for mastering the Hebrew language and for understanding the nuances of the Hebrew Scriptures.

## Aramaic

### History and development of the Aramaic language

The Aramaic language is a Semitic language that originated in the region of modern-day Syria around 1000 BCE. It was widely spoken throughout the Near East and was the lingua franca of the Assyrian and Babylonian empires. Aramaic continued to be spoken in the region even after the Persian and Hellenistic conquests, and it was also adopted as the administrative language of the Achaemenid Persian Empire.

The Aramaic language underwent several changes and developed various dialects over time. One of the most significant developments in the history of Aramaic was the rise of Imperial Aramaic, which became the official language of the Achaemenid Persian Empire in the 6th century BCE. Imperial Aramaic was standardized and used for official documents, diplomatic correspondence, and legal contracts, among other things.

In addition to Imperial Aramaic, several other Aramaic dialects developed, including Jewish Aramaic, Samaritan Aramaic, Syriac, and Mandaic. Each of these dialects had its own unique features and was used by different communities in the Near East.

Aramaic played an important role in the development of the Hebrew Scripture, as many sections of the Old Testament were written in Aramaic. For example, portions of the books of Ezra and Daniel are written in Aramaic, as are some sections of the Talmud and other Jewish texts. Aramaic also had an influence on the development of the New Testament, as it was the language spoken by many of the people in the region at the time.

Today, Aramaic is still spoken by a small number of people in various parts of the world, particularly in Syria, Iraq, and Iran. However, the language has largely been replaced by Arabic as the dominant language of the region.

In summary, the Aramaic language is a Semitic language that originated in the region of modern-day Syria and was widely spoken throughout the Near East. It underwent several changes and developed various dialects, including Imperial Aramaic, which became the official language of the Achaemenid Persian Empire. Aramaic played an important role in the development of the Hebrew Scripture and had an influence on the development of the New Testament.

## The Significance of Aramaic Language

The Aramaic language played an important role in the development of the Old Testament, particularly in the later books of the Hebrew Scripture. There are several reasons why Aramaic is significant for the Old Testament:

**Cultural and Historical Context**: Aramaic was the dominant language of the Near East during the Persian period (539-331 BCE), which is the context in which many of the later books of the Old Testament were written. By using Aramaic in these books, the authors were able to reflect the cultural and historical context in which they were writing.

**Literary Style**: The use of Aramaic in the Old Testament is often associated with a specific literary style that is characterized by symbolic imagery and apocalyptic themes. This style is particularly evident in the book of Daniel, which is written almost entirely in Aramaic.

**Audience**: It is believed that the use of Aramaic in the Old Testament was intended to reach a wider audience, as Aramaic was widely spoken throughout the Near East at the time. By using a language that was more accessible to a broader audience, the authors of the Old Testament were able to convey their message to a larger number of people.

**Theological Significance**: The use of Aramaic in the Old Testament has theological significance as well. For example, the use of Aramaic in the book of Daniel is associated with the idea of universalism, or the belief that God's rule extends beyond the boundaries of Israel to encompass all nations.

In summary, the use of Aramaic in the Old Testament is significant for several reasons, including its reflection of the cultural and historical context in which the books were written,

its association with a specific literary style, its reach to a wider audience, and its theological significance.

### Key Features of the Language

Aramaic is a Semitic language that shares many characteristics with Hebrew and Arabic. Here are some key features of the Aramaic language:

**Alphabet**: Aramaic uses a modified version of the Hebrew alphabet, which includes 22 consonants.

**Grammar**: Aramaic has a complex system of prefixes, suffixes, and infixes that are used to indicate tense, person, and number. Unlike Hebrew, Aramaic has a definite article that is placed before the noun, similar to English "the".

**Vocabulary**: Aramaic has a rich vocabulary that includes many loanwords from other languages, particularly Persian and Greek. It also has its own unique words and phrases that are not found in Hebrew or Arabic.

**Dialects**: There are several different dialects of Aramaic, including Eastern Aramaic (spoken in Iraq, Iran, and Syria), Western Aramaic (spoken in Lebanon and Israel), and Mandaic (spoken by the Mandaeans in Iraq and Iran).

**Influence**: Aramaic has had a significant influence on other languages, particularly Hebrew and Arabic. Many Hebrew words and phrases are derived from Aramaic, and Arabic has also borrowed heavily from Aramaic vocabulary and grammar.

**Written and spoken**: Aramaic has been used as a written and spoken language for thousands of years, and continues to be spoken by small communities in various parts of the world.

Overall, Aramaic is a complex and rich language with a unique history and culture, and has had a significant impact on other languages and cultures throughout history.

## Greek

### History and development of the Greek language

Greek is an Indo-European language that dates back to the 3rd millennium BCE. The earliest form of Greek is known as **Mycenaean Greek**, which was spoken by the Mycenaean civilization in the 16th to 12th centuries BCE. However, the most significant development of Greek occurred during the Classical period (5th to 4th centuries BCE), when it became the language of literature, philosophy, and science.

During the Hellenistic period (4th to 1st centuries BCE), Greek spread throughout the Mediterranean and became the lingua franca of the region. The Greek language continued to evolve and develop over time, with **the Koine Greek** dialect becoming the standard form of the language in the Hellenistic and Roman periods.

Greek also underwent significant changes during the Byzantine period (4th to 15th centuries CE), when it became the language of the Eastern Roman Empire. During this time, the language evolved to include many loanwords from Latin and other languages, and also developed a new writing system known as Byzantine minuscule. Today, Greek is still spoken by millions of people around the world, particularly in Greece and Cyprus. It is also an important language for scholars and students of ancient history, philosophy, and theology.

Overall, the history and development of the Greek language is a complex and fascinating subject, reflecting the cultural and historical changes of the Mediterranean world over thousands of years.

## Significance of the Greek language for the New Testament

The Greek language is of great significance for the New Testament because it was the language in which the majority of the New Testament was originally written. This version of Greek is known as Koine Greek, which was the standard form of the language during the Hellenistic and Roman periods.

The use of Greek for the New Testament was significant because it was a language that was widely spoken throughout the Mediterranean world, and therefore made the text accessible to a larger audience. The New Testament was also written at a time when the Greek language was at its cultural and intellectual peak, making it an ideal language for conveying the complex ideas and concepts contained within the text.

The Greek language also allowed for precise and nuanced theological language, which was important for the development of Christian theology and doctrine. For example, words such

as "logos" (meaning "word" or "reason") and "agape" (meaning "unconditional love") have specific theological meanings that are central to Christian thought and practice. The New Testament was also written in a literary style that was heavily influenced by Greek language, which further emphasizes the importance of the Greek language for understanding the context and meaning of the text.

In summary, the significance of the Greek language for the New Testament cannot be overstated. The use of Greek allowed for the text to be widely accessible, allowed for precise theological language, and was influential in shaping the literary style of the text.

## Key Feature of the Greek Language

The Greek language has several key features that have made it an important language throughout history. Some of these features include:

**Alphabet**: The Greek language uses a unique alphabet, which includes 24 letters. This alphabet has been used as a basis for other alphabets, such as the Cyrillic alphabet.

**Inflection**: Greek is an inflected language, which means that the endings of words change to indicate their grammatical role in a sentence. This allows for a great deal of flexibility and precision in word order.

**Tenses**: Greek has a complex system of tenses, including aorist, imperfect, and perfect, which allows for precise distinctions in time and aspect.

**Vocabulary**: The Greek language has a rich vocabulary, with many words that have nuanced meanings. This has made it an ideal language for expressing complex ideas and concepts.

**Influence**: The Greek language has had a profound influence on Western culture, particularly in the areas of literature, philosophy, and science. Many of the foundational works of Western civilization were written in Greek, and the language continues to be studied and admired to this day. Overall, the Greek language is characterized by its complexity, precision, and influence. These features have made it an important language throughout history, particularly in the areas of literature, philosophy, and science.

## Challenges and opportunities of translating the text from one language to another

Translating the text from one language to another can present both challenges and opportunities. Some of the key challenges and opportunities are:

**Challenges**:

Translating the Scripture from one language to another is a challenging task, as it requires the translator to navigate the complexities of both the source and target languages and cultures. One of the key challenges of translating the Scripture is the cultural and linguistic context of the original text. The Scripture was written in specific historical and cultural contexts, and these contexts often shape the meaning of the text. Therefore, the translator must have a deep understanding of the cultural and linguistic context of the original text to accurately convey its meaning in the target language.

Another challenge of translating the Scripture is the different meanings and nuances of words. Many words in the original languages of the Scripture have multiple meanings and connotations, and the translator must carefully consider the context of the text to determine the appropriate meaning. For example, the Hebrew word "hesed" has been translated into English as "mercy," "loving-kindness," and "steadfast love," among others, each with a slightly different connotation. Thus, the translator must be mindful of the different meanings and nuances of words and choose the appropriate translation that conveys the intended meaning.

Maintaining accuracy and faithfulness to the original text is also a significant challenge in translating the Scripture. The original texts of the Scripture are considered sacred, and many religious traditions hold that they are divinely inspired and cannot be altered or changed. Therefore, the translator must strive to maintain the accuracy and faithfulness of the original text while still making it accessible to a new audience. This requires a balance between staying true to the original text and ensuring that the translation is understandable and meaningful to the target audience.

**Language differences:** Every language has its own grammar, syntax, and vocabulary, which can make it difficult to translate text accurately from one language to another.

**Cultural differences**: Words and phrases that make sense in one culture may not make sense in another culture, making it difficult to accurately convey the meaning of a text.

**Idioms and expressions**: Many languages have idioms and expressions that cannot be translated directly into another language. This can lead to confusion or misunderstanding.

**Multiple meanings**: Some words in one language may have multiple meanings, which can make it difficult to accurately convey the intended meaning in another language.

**Historical context**: Translating ancient texts can be especially challenging because the historical context of the text may be very different from the historical context of the translator.

**Opportunities**:

Translating the Scripture into different languages offers the opportunity to make it accessible to a wider audience. This helps to spread the message of the Scripture and make it available to those who might not have access to it in its original language. It also allows people to connect with the text in a more personal and meaningful way, as they are able to read and understand it in their native language. By making the Scripture available in different languages, it helps to bridge cultural and linguistic barriers, promoting understanding and unity among people of different backgrounds.

Translating the Scripture into different languages can also provide a fresh perspective on the text. Different languages have different grammar structures, syntax, and vocabulary, which can impact the way the text is understood. Translating the Scripture into a new language can therefore highlight certain aspects or nuances of the text that may have been overlooked or less emphasized in its original language. This can help to deepen our understanding and appreciation of the text, and bring new insights and perspectives to its meaning and message. Additionally, different translations may use different idiomatic expressions or phrasing that can help readers to relate to the text in a more personal and relevant way.

**Greater understanding**: Translating a text into another language can provide a deeper understanding of the text and its meaning.

**Broader audience**: Translating a text into another language can make it accessible to a wider audience, which can help to spread the message of the text more widely.

**Preservation**: Translating an ancient text into a modern language can help to preserve the text for future generations.

**Comparative study**: Translating a text into multiple languages can provide opportunities for comparative study, allowing readers to compare and contrast different translations to gain a deeper understanding of the text.

Overall, translating a text from one language to another can be a challenging but rewarding process. It requires careful attention to language and cultural differences, as well as an understanding of the historical context of the text. However, when done well, translation can provide new insights into the text and make it accessible to a wider audience.

### Examples of different translations of the same passage and their differences

One example of different translations of the same passage is the Lord's Prayer found in Matthew 6:9-13. Here are a few examples of how this passage has been translated:

King James Version: "Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen."

New International Version: "This, then, is how you should pray: 'Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name, your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Give us today our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one.'"

The Message: "Our Father in heaven, Reveal who you are. Set the world right; Do what's best - as above, so below. Keep us alive with three square meals. Keep us forgiven with you and forgiving others. Keep us safe from ourselves and the Devil. You're in charge! You can do anything you want! You're ablaze in beauty! Yes. Yes. Yes."

As we can see from these examples, different translations may vary in the use of language, word choice, and phrasing. Some translations, like the King James Version, use more formal and traditional language, while others, like The Message, use more contemporary and colloquial language. These differences can impact the way we understand and interpret the text. It is important to compare and evaluate different translations to gain a more complete understanding of the original meaning and message.

## Critically Evaluating Different Translations of the Scripture

A. Understanding the translator's approach and biases

Translators often have their own biases and theological perspectives that can influence their translation choices. It's important to research the translators and their translation philosophy before choosing a translation.

B. Comparing multiple translations

Comparing multiple translations of the same passage can help identify differences in wording and interpretation. It can also help identify potential biases in a particular translation.

C. Considering the intended audience and purpose of the translation

Different translations may be geared towards different audiences, such as scholars or laypeople. Some translations may prioritize accuracy and literalness, while others may prioritize readability and accessibility.

D. Avoiding common pitfalls when evaluating translations

It's important to avoid cherry-picking translations that fit one's preconceived notions or biases. It's also important to avoid relying solely on a single translation or interpretation, as this can lead to a narrow understanding of the text.

## Versions of the Old Testament

**The Greek Versions the Septuagint (LXX):** Septuagint is a Greek version of the Hebrew Old Testament made in Alexandria for the Jews living in Egypt during the reign of Ptolemy II Philadelphia (255-246 B.C). Septuagint mean in Greek seventy. The title arose from the history of Ptolemy. It was during the reign of Ptolemy Philadelphia that full political and religious rights were granted to the Jews. The translation was made by seventy scholars, who were selected from each of the 12 tribes, and the translation was completed in just seventy-two days, and all Produced identical translations. Among all the versions of the Old Testament, the Septuagint occupies the first place, and it is based on a pre Massoretic Hebrew text. At the beginning of the Christian era there was in existence a complete Old Testament

text in Greek language. We have also three another Greek versions of the Old Testament. When the Jews abandoned the Septuagint and Christians began citing it in their disputes with them, the Jews people immediately issued three new versions in the course of the second century A.D. which are known by the names of their authors:

**The Version of Aquila (ca. 130):** was a new translation of the Old Testament into Greek. It is a very literal translation, and only fragments of his version survive.

**The Version of Symmachus (ca. 170):** The purpose of Symmachus was to make an idiomatic Greek version and, as a result he was al the opposite pole to Aquila. It is an elegant, but free translation; his Greek is pure and idiomatic.

**Theodotion's Revision** (ca. 180-190): occupies the next place of interest in Greek translations of the Old Testament. The exact place of, this work is disputed, but it appears to have been a revision of an earlier Greek version: either of the LXX, possibly of Aquila's, or of another Greek version. Nevertheless, many scholars they use to insist that it is a thorough revision of the Septuagint. These versions have not survived for a long time and only fragments are available of Aquila and Symmachus, Theodotion's Daniel is now extent.

**The Hexaphla of Origen (ca. 240-50)**: When the Septuagint text gradually became corrupt. Origin, with the intension of supplying the Christian community with the correct text, compiled a six-column an addition of the Old Testament, which is known as Hexapla (it is Greek, hex-six + ploos-fold; hence, six fold). In six parallel columns he arranged the Old Testament text in the following order:-

- The Hebrew text
- The Hebrew text transliterated into Greek letters
- Aquila's translation
- Symmachus' translation
- The Septuagint as revised by Origen himself
- Theodotion's translation

The whole page ran to nearly 7000 pages. This great Origen's work was kept in the library at Caesarea, but now only fragments of the entire work are available. The other above versions is also fragments extant.

**The Aramaic Version**

The Targums are Aramaic books of larger sections of the Old Testament. As a general rule, Targums tend to be more periphrastic than literal. They owe their origin to the time when Hebrew fell out of common use among the Jews people in Palestine. Because the ordinary Jew came to speak Aramaic instead of Hebrew, synagogue readings had to be given in Aramaic to be understood. At first this was done orally, but in the course of time these translations came to be written down (during the; lime of Jesus first century A.D.). The Targum fall into three groups, corresponding to the three sections of the Hebrew Scripture:

A, Targum on the Pentateuch: The Palestinian Targum (which is found in Vatican library), The Jerusalem Targum I, The Jerusalem Targum II, The Targum Onqelos;

B, Targum on the Prophets: The Targum Jonathan;

C, The Targum on the Writings: varies unofficial Targums available, but for Danial and Ezra Ntianityehemia there is no Aramaic paraphrase. The Samaritan Pentateuch has its own Targums.

**The Syriac Version (Peshitta)**

The Peshiitta is a translation of the Old Testament in to Syriae which is a dialect of Cast Animate the Syriac 'versions of the Old Testament are the oldest to be made into a vernacular. The common Scripture of the Syriac-speaking communities is the Peshitta. "Peshina" means "simple", that is the text in common use. It was the common language of the market. The Peshitta language was comparable to Koine-Greek and to Vulgate-Latin. The Peshitta Old Testament dates back to the mid-second or early-third century A.D. The Peshitta New Testament was in existence in the 5th century A.D. The Palestine Jews in nearby Syria of our Lord's time before staging Syriac language they spoke Aramaic. Christianity next to Palestine was spread to Syria was there that the followers of Jesus for the first time called Christians (Acts 11:26). From Antioch Christianity spread into Central Asia, India, and as far as China. The basic language of this branch of Christianity was Syriac (or Christian Aramaic that differed from the Aramaic of the Palestinian Jews).

Once the church began to move out from Syria in a missionary effort the need for a version of the Scripture manifested. Finally the Scripture translated into Syriac Peshita. And possibly it was done in the area at or near Edessa by many hands. It was translated from the Hebrew language, though it was rater revised in conformity with the Septuagint.

**The Latin Versions (Vulgate)**

Dining the second and the third centuries the faithful in Rome were speaking Greek, and even the well-known Roman scholars were writing their works in Greek. Although Latin was the official language of the time but all the scriptures were written in Greek. Greek was, the literary-language until the 3rd century. However, Christians in Africa were Latin-speakers; the Latin version made for them from the Septuagint is called Venis Latina. "the old Latin". As early as the 2nd century the Old Latin version were existing in North Africa and Europe. The Latin translation of the Hebrew Scripture prepared by St. Jerome who was commissioned by the Bishops of Rome between 392-405AD. Is known as Vulgate, i.e. the popular version. The Vulgate became the Scripture of the church of the west, and the council of Trent declared it to be the. juridical authentic text to be used in the liturgy. Vulgate remained the official Scripture of the Latin Church until the II Vatican Council.

**The Ethiopic version (Ge'ez)**

The time and circumstances of the planting of the church in Ethiopia is difficult to ascertain. Many scholars they use to say that by the conversion of the Ethiopian Chamber line of the Candace (queen) Christianity introduced to Ethiopia based on the account in Acts 8:26-39. And still others suggest that there were many different apostles namely Mathew, Bartholomew, and Andrew Who come to Ethiopia and preached time gospel. But, here whatever the case, as Christianity moved into Ethiopia, a need arose for another translation of the Scripture. The Old Testament appears to have been translated from Hebrew into Ethiopic, but the New Testament is translated beginning in the fourth century from Greek to Ethiopic. This translation seems to have been completed by the 7th century. The complete translation made by the Syrian Saints who moved to Ethiopia during the Monophysite controversy.

**The Coptic Version**

Coptic is the latest form of ancient Egyptian writing. The name Coptic derivate from Arabic ‘Kibt’ which gave rise to the European form of the name. This system of writing came to be called Coptic, and the Scripture was translated into its several dialects.

**The Armenian Version**

As the Assyrian churches carried out their work of evangelization in the early centuries, they contributed to several secondary translations of the Scripture. They are called a secondary

translation because they were not from the original but it is from the translations of the Originals. One of the foremost is the Armenian. There are two basic traditions concerning the origin of the Armenian version. One attributes it to St. Mesrob (d. 439), a soldier turned missionary who created a new alphabet to assist Sahak (39.-439) in translating the Scripture from the Greek text. The other view claims that Sahak translated it from the Syriac text. The Armenian Old Testament was first translated in the early 5th century.

**English Versions**

As we know at present we have many English versions all over the world. But here we shail try to mention some of the important and popular versions.

i. Rheims-Deuay version (or Douay-Rheims Version): The first Catholic English Scripture is known as Rheims-Douay Version. The work of translation was done mainly by Gregory Martin who published the New Testament first at Rheims (1582) and then the OT at Douay (1609- 1610). U is also known as Douay Version. This translation is based on Latin vulgate.

ii. King James9 Version (K.JV) or Authorized Version (AV) of the Scripture appeared in 1611. This version enjoyed enormous prestige for 350 years. The main reason's tor this are probably the beauty any rhythm of its language.

iii. The Revised Version: King James* Version had two revisions: One in England and the other in U.S.A. The British revision of the KJV is called Revised Version: The NT of RV was published in 1881 and the OT in 1885.

iv. American Standard Version (ASV): The American Scholars, who were invited to lake part in the production of the Revised Version, suggested extensive changes. But their Suggestions were not agreed upon. Later in 1901, the American revision was published as the American Standard Version.

v. The Revised Standard Version (RSV): The American Standard Version was again revised by a Committee of Protestant scholar and there appeared what is known as the Revised Standard Version (RSV). The New Testament appeared in 1946 and the Old Testament in 1952, and the Apocrypha (Deutero-canonical Books) in 1957. A second edition of the New Testament appeared in 1957. A second edition of the New Testament appeared in 1971 with minor changes. Later the entire Scripture was completely revised and published in the year 1989 as the New Revised Standard Version (NRSV).

### 3.4. The Text of the New Testament

The books of the New Testament were all written roughly between. A.D. 50- 110. And immediate]) after their publication most of them were recognized as inspired and canonical. Though we do not have the autographs of the sacred writers, we are in possession of their authentic of The Greek New Testament as we have it now is substantially unchanged and uncorrupted and is critically certain.

### The Versions of the New Testament

Our discussions can be quite brief, for the New Testament versions do not have a complicated history like that of the Old Testament versions. This is something easily understandable, because the New Testament is a tiny volume in comparison with the Old Testament. Around 175 A.D. Tatian, a disciple of St. Justin the Martyr, compiled a harmony of the Gospels in Syriac, the Diatessaron, which was soon translated into Greek. The unfortunate thing is that the its original is no more extant. There are also other versions of the New Testament such as the Vulgate, Coptic, Ethiopic, the Armenian and others.

## Chapter 9:

## Reading the Scriptures from an Orthodox Perspective

This lesson provides an introduction to reading the Scriptures from an Orthodox Christian perspective. Through a close reading of selected Scriptural texts and commentaries, the course aims to deepen students' understanding of the distinctive features of Orthodox Scriptural reading.

**At the end of this lesson, students will be able to:**

Understand the basic principles and practices of reading Holy Scriptures.

Reflect on one's own spiritual and ethical development through the process of reading and interpreting Holy Scriptures.

Develop personal strategies for reading and engaging with Holy Scriptures in Orthodox Tradition.

***Recommend Reading Materials***

Pentiuc, Eugen J., ed. *The Oxford Handbook of the Bible in Orthodox Christianity*. Oxford University Press, 2022. Part IV. Chapter 25.

## Reading the Scriptures from an Orthodox Perspective

A. Importance of Understanding Orthodox Scriptural Reading

The study and interpretation of the Holy Scriptures hold immense significance within the Orthodox Christian tradition. The Orthodox Church views the Scriptures as sacred texts inspired by God, conveying divine truth and guiding believers in matters of faith, morality, and spirituality. As such, acquiring a deep understanding of Orthodox Scriptural reading is vital for Orthodox Christians seeking to develop a rich and meaningful spiritual life.

Orthodox Scriptural reading involves a distinctive approach that emphasizes the continuity of the Church's teaching throughout history and the interplay between Scripture, tradition, and the liturgical life of the Church. It is rooted in the belief that the Scriptures are not meant to be interpreted solely through individualistic or isolated lenses but rather within the context of the faith community and the guidance of the Holy Spirit.

By studying the Scriptures from an Orthodox perspective, believers gain insights into the theological and spiritual treasures handed down by the Church Fathers, who have offered profound commentaries and interpretations throughout the centuries. These insights illuminate the hidden meanings and symbolic depth contained within the texts, enabling readers to delve into the spiritual riches present in the Scriptures.

Furthermore, understanding Orthodox Scriptural reading facilitates the integration of its principles and practices into one's personal spiritual and ethical development. Through engaging with the Scriptures, believers are encouraged to cultivate virtues, combat vices, and shape their moral decision-making processes in accordance with the teachings of the Church.

In an academic context, exploring Orthodox Scriptural reading provides scholars with a unique lens through which to approach Scriptural theology. It offers an opportunity to examine the interplay between theology, exegesis, and spirituality within the Orthodox tradition, contributing to a broader understanding of the multifaceted nature of Scriptural interpretation across different religious and theological frameworks.

In conclusion, understanding Orthodox Scriptural reading is of paramount importance for both Orthodox Christians and scholars. It enables believers to deepen their spiritual and ethical development, embrace the wisdom of the Church Fathers, and engage with the

Scriptures in a manner that aligns with the Orthodox tradition. Moreover, it enriches academic discourse by providing a distinct perspective on Scriptural interpretation.

## II. Basic Principles and Practices of Reading Holy Scriptures

### A. Sacredness and Divine Inspiration of the Scriptures

One of the fundamental principles in Orthodox Scriptural reading is the recognition of the sacredness and divine inspiration of the Scriptures. The Orthodox Church affirms that the Scriptures are not merely human writings but are imbued with the breath of God, making them unique and authoritative sources of divine revelation. Orthodox Christians hold the belief that God inspired the human authors of the Scriptures, guiding them in the process of writing to convey His divine message. This divine inspiration ensures that the Scriptures contain the truth necessary for salvation and provide a reliable guide for faith and practice.

The sacredness of the Scriptures is manifested in the way they are revered and treated within Orthodox liturgical and devotional practices. The Holy Scriptures are read aloud during the services, and they are handled with great care and respect. This reverence reflects the understanding that the Scriptures are not mere historical or literary texts but are living and transformative words of God. Orthodox Scriptural reading also acknowledges the presence of the Holy Spirit in the interpretation and understanding of the Scriptures. Believers approach the Scriptures with humility and openness, seeking the guidance of the Holy Spirit to illuminate their hearts and minds and to discern the deeper meanings embedded in the text. Moreover, the Orthodox Church recognizes the canon of the Scriptures, which consists of the Old and New Testaments. The Church carefully preserved and handed down these canonical books, considering them as the authoritative Word of God. The selection and acceptance of the canon were guided by the consensus and discernment of the early Church Fathers, who recognized the inherent spiritual value and divine inspiration of these writings.

In summary, the Orthodox understanding of Scriptural reading emphasizes the sacredness and divine inspiration of the Scriptures. Believers approach the Scriptures with reverence, recognizing them as the living Word of God. The presence of the Holy Spirit is sought in the interpretation and understanding of the texts, and the canonical books are upheld as sources of divine revelation. By acknowledging the sacredness and divine inspiration of the Scriptures, Orthodox Christians establish a foundation for their engagement with the Word of God.

**B. Understanding the Scriptures as a Unified Whole**

In Orthodox Scriptural reading, the Scriptures are viewed as a unified whole, where the Old and New Testaments are interconnected and mutually illuminating. This holistic approach recognizes the continuity and coherence of God's revelation throughout history, revealing His plan of salvation for humanity.

Orthodox Christians understand that the Scriptures form a single narrative that unfolds progressively from Genesis to Revelation. The Old Testament prepares the way for the coming of Christ, while the New Testament fulfills and reveals the deeper meanings and realities prefigured in the Old Testament. The events, prophecies, symbols, and typologies found in the Old Testament find their fulfillment and ultimate meaning in the person and work of Jesus Christ.

Within this unified framework, the Church Fathers and Orthodox theologians emphasize the importance of reading the Old Testament in light of the New Testament. They see the New Testament as the key to unlocking the hidden meanings and spiritual truths embedded in the Old Testament. The Old Testament serves as a foreshadowing and preparation for the coming of Christ, and the New Testament provides the interpretive lens through which the fulfillment of God's promises and the revelation of His grace are understood.

This understanding of the Scriptures as a unified whole also extends to the recognition of the Church as the living body of Christ. The Church is seen as the continuation of the scriptural narrative and the embodiment of God's ongoing work of salvation in the world. The Scriptures are not detached from the life and worship of the Church but are intimately connected to it. The liturgical practices, prayers, and teachings of the Church draw heavily from the Scriptures, enriching the understanding and interpretation of the Word of God.

By approaching the Scriptures as a unified whole, Orthodox Scriptural reading promotes a holistic understanding of God's revelation and fosters a deeper appreciation for the interplay between the Old and New Testaments. It invites believers to explore the profound connections and spiritual truths that transcend the boundaries of time and culture, ultimately leading them to encounter the living Word of God, Jesus Christ, who is revealed throughout the Scriptures.

In conclusion, understanding the Scriptures as a unified whole is a central principle in Orthodox Scriptural reading. It emphasizes the interconnectedness of the Old and New

Testaments, revealing God's progressive revelation and the fulfillment of His promises in Jesus Christ. By recognizing the unity of the Scriptures, Orthodox Christians gain a comprehensive perspective that enriches their spiritual journey and nurtures their relationship with God.

**C. Contextual Interpretation of Scripture within Orthodox Tradition**

Orthodox Scriptural reading places a strong emphasis on the contextual interpretation of the Scriptures within the rich tradition of the Orthodox Church. Contextual interpretation involves understanding the Scriptures in light of their historical, cultural, and theological context, as well as within the broader framework of Orthodox Tradition.

**Historical and Cultural Context:**

Recognizing the historical and cultural background of the scriptural texts helps to understand the original intentions, circumstances, and challenges faced by the authors and recipients of the Scriptures.

Studying the social, political, and religious milieu of the scriptural era provides valuable insights into the customs, practices, and beliefs that influenced the text's composition.

**Theological Context:**

Orthodox Scriptural reading acknowledges the theological framework within which the Scriptures are interpreted. It aligns with the doctrinal teachings and dogmas of the Orthodox Church, ensuring the preservation of orthodox beliefs.

Theological context includes the understanding of God's nature, the doctrine of the Trinity, Christology, soteriology, and the sacramental life of the Church. These theological principles guide the interpretation of the Scriptures and prevent misinterpretation or distortion.

**Patristic Tradition:**

The Church Fathers, renowned theologians, and spiritual guides from the early centuries of Christianity, play a crucial role in Orthodox Scriptural interpretation. Their writings and

commentaries provide valuable insights into the deeper meanings, spiritual dimensions, and practical applications of the Scriptures.

Patristic tradition serves as a guide for understanding the Scriptures in a manner consistent with the teachings and experiences of the early Christian Church. It helps to maintain the continuity and fidelity to the apostolic faith.

**Liturgical Context:**

Orthodox Scriptural reading is intimately linked to the liturgical life of the Church. The lectionary, which selects specific passages for each liturgical season and feast, provides a liturgical context for the interpretation of the Scriptures.

The prayers, hymns, and liturgical texts draw extensively from the Scriptures, creating a dynamic interplay between the scriptural text and the worshiping community. Liturgical context helps believers to engage with the Scriptures in a communal and participatory manner. By interpreting the Scriptures within their appropriate contexts, Orthodox Scriptural reading ensures a faithful understanding of the Word of God. It guards against arbitrary or individualistic interpretations and promotes an interpretation that is rooted in the historical, theological, patristic, and liturgical dimensions of Orthodox Tradition.

In conclusion, contextual interpretation is a key principle in Orthodox Scriptural reading. It involves understanding the Scriptures within their historical and cultural context, aligning interpretation with Orthodox theological teachings, drawing insights from the patristic tradition, and considering the liturgical context of the Church. This approach provides a solid foundation for faithful and meaningful engagement with the Scriptures within the Orthodox Tradition.

**D. Importance of the Church Fathers and Patristic Writings**

The Church Fathers and their writings hold significant importance in Orthodox Scriptural reading. The Church Fathers are revered as authoritative guides and witnesses to the apostolic tradition, providing valuable insights and interpretations of the Scriptures. Their writings serve as a rich resource for understanding the deeper meanings, spiritual insights, and practical applications of the Word of God.

**Continuity of Apostolic Tradition:**

The Church Fathers lived in the early centuries of Christianity and were close in time to the apostles and their immediate disciples. They embody the continuity of the apostolic tradition and bear witness to the faith and teachings passed down from generation to generation. Their writings reflect the theological and spiritual understanding of the early Church, providing valuable insights into the interpretive methods, theological perspectives, and spiritual practices of the early Christians.

**Patristic Exegesis and Interpretation:**

The Church Fathers' commentaries and exegesis of the Scriptures offer profound insights into the meaning and significance of the scriptural texts. Their interpretations draw on their deep knowledge of the Scriptures, their theological expertise, and their personal experiences of living the Christian life. Patristic interpretation emphasizes the spiritual and allegorical dimensions of the Scriptures, revealing hidden spiritual truths and symbolic connections between various passages. This approach enriches the understanding of the Scriptures and provides spiritual nourishment to believers.

**Doctrinal Orthodoxy:**

The Church Fathers played a vital role in formulating and defending orthodox Christian doctrine. Their writings addressed theological controversies and heresies of their time, articulating and safeguarding the orthodox faith. In Orthodox Scriptural reading, the Church Fathers' writings serve as a touchstone for ensuring the fidelity and consistency of interpretation with the orthodox teachings of the Church. Their writings offer a safeguard against erroneous or distorted interpretations.

**Personal Spiritual Guidance:**

The Church Fathers' writings are not only a scholarly resource but also a spiritual guide for Orthodox believers. Their writings provide practical wisdom, moral guidance, and insights for personal spiritual growth and transformation. By studying the works of the Church Fathers, believers can deepen their understanding of the Scriptures, nurture their spiritual life, and find guidance for navigating the challenges and struggles they face in their journey of faith. In Orthodox Scriptural reading, the Church Fathers and their writings are regarded as invaluable resources that enhance the understanding and interpretation of the Scriptures. Their insights and interpretations, grounded in the apostolic tradition and guided by the Holy

Spirit, provide a solid foundation for engaging with the Word of God in a faithful and transformative manner.

In conclusion, the Church Fathers and their writings play a crucial role in Orthodox Scriptural reading. They embody the continuity of the apostolic tradition, offer profound insights into the Scriptures, safeguard orthodoxy, and provide spiritual guidance for believers. By studying their works, Orthodox Christians can deepen their understanding of the Scriptures and nourish their spiritual lives in accordance with the teachings of the Church.

**E. Recognition of the Spiritual and Allegorical Dimensions of Scripture**

In Orthodox Scriptural reading, there is a recognition and appreciation of the spiritual and allegorical dimensions present within the Scriptures. This approach goes beyond a purely literal interpretation and delves into the deeper spiritual truths and symbolism embedded in the text.

**Spiritual Dimension:**

Orthodox Scriptural reading acknowledges that the Scriptures contain not only historical narratives and moral teachings but also spiritual truths that speak to the inner life of believers. The Scriptures are seen as a means of encountering and communing with God on a spiritual level. By recognizing the spiritual dimension, readers are encouraged to approach the Scriptures with a receptive heart, seeking to encounter the living Word of God and allowing the Holy Spirit to illuminate their understanding and transform their lives.

**Allegorical Interpretation:**

The allegorical interpretation of Scripture is a distinctive feature of Orthodox Scriptural reading. It involves seeing deeper symbolic meanings and connections within the text that go beyond the literal narrative. Allegorical interpretation recognizes that certain events, characters, and objects in the Scriptures can be understood as symbols or types that point to higher spiritual truths or foreshadow future realities. These symbols and types are often understood in relation to Christ and His redemptive work. By engaging in allegorical interpretation, believers can uncover hidden spiritual truths and draw out the broader theological and moral implications of the biblical narratives.

**Typology:**

Typology is closely related to allegorical interpretation and plays a significant role in Orthodox Scriptural reading. It involves identifying patterns or "types" in the Old Testament that prefigure or find their fulfillment in the person and work of Jesus Christ. Typology recognizes that certain individuals, events, and institutions in the Old Testament serve as foreshadowings or "types" of Christ and His saving mission. This understanding deepens the connection between the Old and New Testaments and reveals the unity and coherence of God's redemptive plan.

By recognizing the spiritual and allegorical dimensions of Scripture, Orthodox Scriptural reading allows for a more profound and transformative engagement with the Word of God. It opens the door to spiritual insights, personal reflection, and a deeper communion with God. This approach enriches the reading experience by moving beyond a surface-level understanding and embracing the profound truths and wisdom contained within the text.

In conclusion, Orthodox Scriptural reading emphasizes the recognition of the spiritual and allegorical dimensions present in the Scriptures. By embracing the spiritual dimension and engaging in allegorical interpretation and typology, believers can delve into the deeper meanings and symbolic connections within the text. This approach facilitates a transformative encounter with the Word of God, fostering spiritual growth and deepening one's relationship with God.

## IV. Strategies for Reading and Engaging with Holy Scriptures in Orthodox Tradition

### A. Regular and Disciplined Reading of Scripture

Regular and disciplined reading of Scripture is a fundamental strategy for engaging with the Holy Scriptures in Orthodox Tradition. Orthodox Christians are encouraged to establish a consistent habit of reading and studying the Scriptures individually or within a community.

Daily Reading: Orthodox believers are encouraged to set aside dedicated time each day for reading the Scriptures. This regular practice allows for a gradual and systematic immersion in the Word of God, fostering a deepening understanding and spiritual growth.

Lectionary Readings: Following the lectionary readings prescribed by the Church is another way to engage with Scripture regularly. The lectionary provides a structured plan for reading specific passages throughout the liturgical year, ensuring a comprehensive exposure to the entire Scripture.

**B. Engaging in Lectio Divina and Contemplative Prayer**

Lectio Divina, meaning "divine reading," is a method of prayerful Scripture reading that encourages contemplation and a deep personal encounter with the Word of God. This ancient practice, rooted in monastic tradition, involves four stages:

Reading (lectio): Reading a selected passage of Scripture slowly and attentively, allowing the words to penetrate the heart and mind.

Meditation (meditatio): Reflecting on the meaning of the text and considering its relevance to one's life and spiritual journey.

Prayer (oratio): Responding to God's Word in prayer, expressing thoughts, feelings, and desires inspired by the Scripture passage.

Contemplation (contemplatio): Resting in silence and openness to God's presence, allowing His grace to work in the depths of one's being.

Engaging in lectio divina and contemplative prayer allows for a transformative and personal encounter with the Scriptures, leading to spiritual growth and deeper communion with God.

**C. Utilizing Orthodox Commentaries and Resources**

Orthodox commentaries and resources provide valuable insights and guidance for understanding and interpreting the Scriptures within the context of Orthodox Tradition. The writings of the Church Fathers, contemporary Orthodox theologians, and reputable Orthodox scholars offer depth and richness to one's study of the Scriptures.

Patristic Commentaries: Exploring the commentaries of the Church Fathers provides a unique perspective rooted in the early Christian tradition. These commentaries offer spiritual and theological insights into the meaning and application of the Scriptures.

Contemporary Orthodox Books: There are numerous books written by contemporary Orthodox theologians and scholars that delve into various aspects of Scriptural interpretation, providing valuable resources for study and reflection.

**D. Participating in Liturgical Worship and Sacraments**

Active participation in liturgical worship and sacraments is a vital aspect of engaging with the Holy Scriptures in Orthodox Tradition. The liturgical services of the Church incorporate

extensive readings from the Scriptures, hymns, and prayers that nourish and illuminate the understanding of God's Word.

Divine Liturgy: Regular attendance and active participation in the Divine Liturgy expose believers to Scriptural readings and prayers that reinforce the teachings and themes found in the Scriptures. The Liturgy provides a holistic and communal encounter with the Word of God.

Sacraments: The sacraments, such as Holy Baptism, Holy Chrismation, Holy Communion, and Holy Confession, are intimately connected to the Scriptures and contribute to a deeper understanding and experience of God's Word.

**E. Seeking Guidance from a Spiritual Father**

Orthodox believers are encouraged to seek guidance from a spiritual father or mother, often a monastic or experienced spiritual guide, who can provide personalized guidance and direction in their Scriptural reading and spiritual journey. These spiritual guides offer insights, advice, and prayers that assist in navigating the challenges and complexities of interpreting and applying the Scriptures.

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